Game of Hearts

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Game of Hearts

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Mydei’s out of soccer, and honestly, he’s just trying to avoid a breakdown. Enter Phainon, who apparently didn’t get the memo about personal space or letting Mydei move on. Between accidental love confessions, awkward tension, and some truly questionable choices, Mydei’s life is spiraling faster than his old soccer career.

(Or: One confusing reunion, too many mixed signals, and a whole lot of “wait, did that just happen?” moments.)

Notes

This fucker took me nearly 4 weeks and 2 all-nighters to write, and an extra 4 hours today, SO PLEASE I HOPE YOU ENJOY READING IT, I put blood sweat and you have no idea how many fucking tears writing this

Djdhdjskskandjsmanska I’m tweaking out y’all

I already have the second chapter written, so I’ll post it in a few minutes or hours since my god, I have to backspace through the whole thing because for some reason every time I make a blank line it double spaces?? Plus the ITALICSSSSSSS😭😭😭

See the end of the work for more notes

Unfinished Business

The soft hum of the television filled the quiet room, an idle soundtrack to Mydei's restless mind. The faint glow from the screen illuminated the cluttered apartment—empty coffee mugs stacked haphazardly, a half-open book on the couch beside him, and the ever-present reminder of his new reality: a knee brace that sat beside him like an unwanted companion.

It was an early afternoon, but Mydei hadn't bothered to leave his couch. There was no need to. He didn't have a schedule anymore—no early morning runs, no tight training regimens, no match preparations. All that was gone, replaced by the monotonous routines of a life that no longer felt his own. The pain in his knee had become a constant, an ache that settled into his bones, no matter how still he was. He tried to ignore it as best he could, but some days it was louder than others.

The game on the television was nothing new, just another replay of one of Phainon's recent matches. The familiar faces of players, the aggressive tackles, the beautiful fluid passes—he had lived it. He had been it. The fast-paced action of soccer, the sharp focus, the brutal intensity, all of it had once been his world. The crowd's roar, the energy that pulsed through him as he sprinted across the pitch—it had been so effortless back then.

But that was before the injury.

He turned his eyes away from the screen, letting the pictures blur as he closed them for a moment. It wasn't the game that consumed him now, not anymore. It was the memory—the sudden, sharp moment when everything changed. That one instant had led him down an entirely different path.

It was late in the first half of the match. His team was pushing forward, the ball coming to him in a fast break. He was poised to make his signature move—a sharp cut to the left, followed by a cross to his forward, setting up a perfect chance to score. But as his foot planted, as he began to push off the turf to make the turn, he felt it. A sharp, sickening snap. The world seemed to freeze for a moment, the sound of it echoing in his ears.

The pain hit him a second later—blinding, all-consuming. His knee buckled beneath him, sending him crashing to the ground, his body contorting in ways it shouldn't have. He couldn't breathe, couldn't focus on anything except the overwhelming agony that shot through his leg. Every movement felt like it was fighting against him, like his body was betraying him in the most unforgiving way.

He could still hear the trainer's voice, the panic in it, the urgency. The next few minutes blurred into an unrecognizable mess of voices and movement. The crowd's cheers turned to confused murmurs, the stadium atmosphere shifting as Mydei was helped off the field. He couldn't even remember getting to the locker room, only the stark white of the lights and the pressure of hands on his leg, trying to stabilize it.

The tests, the scans, the long days of waiting, all felt like part of a different life. The diagnosis was the one thing that would change everything: *Severe ACL tear. Chronic instability. Full recovery is unlikely.* It didn't matter how much therapy he went through, or how hard he worked to get back to the game. His knee would never be the same.

In those early days after the injury, Mydei had refused to believe it. He'd ignored the doctor's words, even as his body told him otherwise. He'd worked through the pain, pushing harder than he ever had, telling himself it was just temporary, that he would come back stronger. He had been so determined, so focused on returning to his former glory that the reality of what was happening didn't truly sink in.

It wasn't until months later, during one of his rehab sessions, when he tried to take a step—just a step—and his knee gave out again that the finality of it hit him. The pang of disappointment. The heavyweight of resignation. It was at that moment that he knew: *This was it. This was all I have now.*

The hardest part hadn't been the physical pain, though. It had been the knowledge that his career, his entire identity, was tied to that one injury. The thought that he would never play again, never feel the rush of a game, never compete in front of a roaring crowd—those were the things that had broken him. Not the pain, not the endless days in rehab, but the loss of himself.

It wasn’t long before the media had spun their narrative—retirement due to injury, sure, but the rumors swirled. They couldn’t resist turning it into something more salacious. They had painted him as a has-been , washed up and left behind by the sport that had defined him. They said he was weak. They said he didn’t have the grit to fight through it. It wasn’t just the press that hurt him, though—it was the way the world had moved on without him. His friends had moved on. His teammates, former rivals, and even Phainon had moved on.

But not Phainon. Phainon had stayed.

Even when the calls from his teammates stopped coming, even when the invitations to “grab a drink” stopped, Phainon kept reaching out. It wasn’t often, but it was consistent. He never let Mydei feel entirely forgotten. Phainon sent the occasional text, checked in, and asked how the rehab was going. It wasn’t much, but it was enough to remind Mydei that he wasn’t completely alone.

And even though it wasn’t much, there was always the reminder of Phainon’s brilliance in the sport—his name plastered across billboards, magazine covers, and endless headlines. The media’s sweetheart. The golden boy. Phainon was a professional who could do no wrong. Winning title after title, his natural talent and drive make him an unstoppable force on the field. It was a game of jet-setting for him now, traveling country to country, competing in the biggest leagues, always in the spotlight.

The last time Mydei had seen Phainon in person had been at the championship game—a competition that had been the talk of the year. Phainon’s team had won the prestigious *Copa de la Liga* , a major international championship, with Phainon scoring the winning goal in the final match. It had been a spectacular moment for Phainon, a moment of glory that only seemed to add to his already massive reputation.

The headlines had been everywhere— *Phainon’s Victory Secures Another Title* —and the way the world had celebrated him only reminded Mydei of everything he had lost. But he couldn’t be angry. He couldn’t bring himself to resent Phainon for it. Phainon deserved every accolade and every

recognition that came his way. He had worked for it, and Mydei wouldn't begrudge him that.

But damn, the stabbing feeling still lingered when he saw Phainon's face in those headlines, winning another title while Mydei was left behind in the shadows.

As Phainon's name filled the screen for another highlight, Mydei caught himself thinking about the distance between them, the rare times they managed to see each other. Phainon was always on the move—always chasing the next game, the next title. It made sense, but it didn't make the space any easier to bear.

He's just doing his job , Mydei reminded himself, quickly pushing the thought away. *He has a life, just like I have mine now.*

It had been years since the injury, but sometimes it felt like it had only happened yesterday.

The room felt a little quieter now, the hum of the TV almost like background noise as Mydei scrolled idly through his phone. He didn't expect to see anything new, just the usual assortment of headlines—sports gossip, random fan photos, and the occasional interview. But one headline caught his attention.

The picture beside it was one he recognized immediately: Phainon, grinning like the sun itself had exploded in his chest, lifting Cyrene into the air after winning the *Copa de la Liga* finals. Her laughter was infectious, her face framed by the light of the stadium's floodlights, eyes sparkling as Phainon spun her around. She was always so full of warmth, so kind, so effortless in her joy.

The headline read: *Phainon Celebrates Championship Win with Special Guest Cyrene—A Bond Stronger Than the Game?*

Mydei let out a breath he hadn't realized he'd been holding. He couldn't help but smile at the picture, even though it dug at something deep in his chest. They were perfect for each other, weren't they?

Cyrene wasn’t like the others, the people who hovered around Phainon in the media, desperate for a piece of his spotlight. She was genuine, unpretentious—one of the few people who had always treated him with kindness, even when the world around him was spinning out of control. Mydei had seen it in the way she interacted with Phainon: the subtle touches, the way her eyes softened when she looked at him, the way they could speak without words. It was the kind of connection he had always envied, the kind of relationship he could only wish for.

And yet…

There was still the weird, inexplicable bond he shared with Phainon, the one that had existed long before Cyrene had come into the picture. It wasn’t exactly a friendship—at least not the kind they had once shared when they were on the same team. It wasn’t a rivalry either, not anymore. It was something…in between. Something that lived in the gray area of what they used to have and what they could be now, in this strange situation they’d found themselves in.

Mydei was ashamed to admit it, but he was selfish about it. He didn’t want to let it go, even though he knew he probably should. He wasn’t sure when it had started, this something between him and Phainon, but it had always felt so easy when they were together. It was almost like picking up where they left off, no matter how much time had passed.

Maybe that was the problem.

Phainon had moved on—his world was Cyrene now, his victories, his life. And Mydei was just left in the periphery, still clinging to whatever was left of their past. But he wasn’t ready to let it go. Not yet. Not when it still felt like there was something there , even if it was just the echoes of their old friendship, the faintest hint of something more.

But no. Mydei quickly banished that thought. He couldn’t be selfish. Not with someone like Cyrene in Phainon’s life. She was good for him. She made him happy. And Phainon deserved that happiness, no matter how bittersweet it was for Mydei.

Still, the ache in his chest didn’t go away, even as he kept his eyes glued to the photo of Phainon and Cyrene, laughing and spinning in each other’s arms.

Maybe one day, Mydei thought, *he’ll see me the way he sees her. But not now. Not yet.*

He immediately cut that line of thought off. He couldn’t be thinking like this, not anymore. Not when the truth was painfully clear—Phainon was never going to see him that way. He’d had his chances, hadn’t he? Their moments, the lingering touches, the way they’d always been able to talk for hours about nothing at all—those were just the comfortable rhythms of an old friendship, nothing more. Nothing that should’ve meant anything more.

He needed to let go of this. The moments when their fingers brushed against each other on accident, the times Phainon had leaned just a little too close when speaking to him, the occasional late-night phone calls where Phainon’s voice would slip into something softer, more intimate—those things didn’t mean anything. Not really.

And yet, every time Phainon would smile at him, that warmth would flood Mydei’s chest. It would feel like something more like he was the one Phainon was letting in—letting closer, even when it was obvious that no one else would. There were times, small moments in between when Mydei could swear there was something there. A glance that lingered a second too long, an unspoken understanding when they didn’t need to say a word. He thought maybe—just maybe—he was special to Phainon in some way that no one else was.

But no. He couldn’t let himself get carried away with that idea. Phainon had Cyrene now. He was happy. He deserved that. Mydei was selfish for even hoping that this—whatever this was between them—could be more than it ever would be.

Still, when Phainon’s name popped up on his phone screen, a part of him couldn’t help the way his heart quickened, the way his thumb hovered for a second too long before he answered. They spoke often, more often than Mydei was ready to admit. There were times when their conversations

would flow seamlessly, their easy rapport making it feel like nothing had changed. Phainon would ask about his day, about the injury, about how he was feeling—sometimes with an easy, casual tone, sometimes with something softer, something that felt like concern.

It was moments like those that Mydei found himself reaching for his phone even when he knew he shouldn't, moments where he felt like he was holding onto a thread that would unravel if he let go. Phainon had been there when Mydei was struggling, long after the injury ended his career. He'd visited and helped him through the worst days. Mydei would never forget that. But there was always that lingering distance now, that invisible line between them that neither of them ever seemed willing to cross.

It wasn't that Phainon was indifferent—far from it. He had a way of making Mydei feel like he mattered like he was still important. But it was the way Phainon was with Cyrene that always left a bitter taste in his mouth. He was different from her, in a way that Mydei couldn't ignore. There was an ease to it, an openness, a depth that Mydei could never seem to replicate. The way Phainon would lean into her touch, the way he'd smile at her as though the rest of the world faded away when she was around.

I'm not jealous, Mydei repeated to himself, trying to quell the unease that churned in his stomach. *I'm not jealous*. But damn it, he couldn't help it. He wasn't just watching Phainon from the sidelines anymore. He was watching him from the edge of something he couldn't quite define—half-friend, half-something else—while Cyrene had the full version of him. And that… that was hard to swallow.

Yet here he was, clinging to the little moments they still had. The texts, the calls, the quiet, unspoken understanding. He wanted to be content with that, to let go of these feelings that were too tangled to sort out. But every time Phainon's name lit up his phone screen, or when he would hear Phainon's voice just a little too close, Mydei felt that pull. That hope. That little spark that made him want to believe in something more.

The worst part was, he wasn't sure if Phainon even realized what he was doing. Did Phainon know the effect he had on him? Or was this all just some unintentional flirtation in the form of friendship that Mydei was

reading into too much? He couldn’t know for sure, and that was the hardest part.

But one thing was for certain—he couldn’t keep pretending that the pain in his chest was going to go away on its own. He couldn’t keep pretending that watching Phainon and Cyrene together didn’t tear at something deep inside him.

Mydei couldn’t keep watching them. Phainon and Cyrene, were always so effortless in their affection, so open with their smiles, their touches, the way they seemed to have no reservations in their connection. It made his stomach twist. His hands, once steady and calm, were now clenched into fists at his sides, his chest tight with something he didn’t know how to name.

He wanted Phainon to be happy, wanted him to find the kind of love and peace that was so obvious between him and Cyrene. That was the truth, wasn’t it? It was easy to say that to himself, easy to repeat. He wasn’t jealous, he wasn’t bitter… but in moments like this, when Phainon would pull Cyrene close, smile at her with that look in his eyes that Mydei had never once received, the ache would come back tenfold. He couldn’t deny it any longer.

It wasn’t just about wanting Phainon to be happy. It was about wanting Phainon to notice him. To see him. To see him *in the way he needed* . Mydei wanted to believe that, deep down, there was something there, something he wasn’t imagining. But whenever he watched Phainon and Cyrene together, he felt like an outsider in his own heart. He wasn’t even sure what he was any more in Phainon’s life—was he a friend? A companion? A distant memory of someone Phainon used to rely on? The more he saw, the more he began to feel like a shadow in the periphery, someone who didn’t belong in the world Phainon had built around himself.

A frustrated, low growl slipped from Mydei’s throat, and he slammed both his hands down on the table in front of him. He couldn’t sit here anymore. He couldn’t keep doing this to himself, letting his emotions spiral, letting his mind run wild over things he couldn’t control.

He needed to get out.

Without giving himself another moment to think, Mydei stood up abruptly, his chair scraping loudly across the floor. His legs felt stiff as he moved, his body protesting the sudden movement, but he ignored it. He grabbed his jacket, yanking it on over his shoulders before heading toward the door.

It wasn't the first time he'd done this—walked out to clear his head, trying to escape the rising frustration inside him. But this time felt different. The weight of the past few years was heavier today, pressing down on him more than usual.

Once outside, he inhaled deeply, trying to breathe through the knot in his chest. The city around him was still bustling, people going about their lives, completely unaware of the turmoil inside him. And that was fine. That's how it should be now. Nobody cared about Mydei anymore. He wasn't the golden boy of soccer, the one everyone wanted to see, the one everyone talked about. Now, he was just another face in the crowd.

At first, that felt like a relief—no more cameras in his face, no more invasive questions about his injury, no more false sympathy from reporters trying to catch him at his lowest. He was just… normal. And for the most part, he appreciated that. The quiet, the anonymity—it was a kind of peace. But now and then, the absence of the spotlight stung. There were moments when he missed being on the field, the adrenaline of the game, the thrill of the crowd cheering his name. But more than that, he missed feeling important, missed the sense of purpose that had driven him through his career.

Now, all he had was the nagging reminder of what he used to be—what he could've been, if not for that one fateful moment, that one *snap* that had changed everything.

Mydei rubbed his eyes, exhaling slowly, trying to shake off the feeling. He didn't have time for this right now. He needed to focus on something, anything else. His body might've healed physically, but the injury lingered in other ways. In the quiet moments of his life, it crept in. He could feel it in

the stiffness of his knee every time he moved too quickly, the constant gnawing of it that would flare up when he stood for too long.

It had been years since the ACL tear, and Mydei had mostly gotten used to the dull pain, the way it reminded him of what he'd lost. There were days when it wasn't as bad, days when he could walk without thinking about it, but there were also days when he felt the weight of it in every step. Days when his knee locked up unexpectedly, forcing him to stop whatever he was doing just to wait for it to loosen again.

And no matter how many times he tried to ignore it, it was there. It was always there.

There was no escaping it—not even in his day-to-day life. Sometimes, when he was walking down the street, just trying to get from one place to another, he could feel people staring. Not in the way they used to, when they were fascinated by his skill or his star power. Now, it was pitying stares. The looks that lingered just a second too long when they noticed the slight limp in his step. Mydei hated it, hated the reminder that he was no longer the athlete he used to be.

But what could he do? The injury had changed everything, and now, all he could do was keep moving forward.

Just keep moving forward, he repeated to himself, taking a slow breath.

He didn't have Phainon's success, didn't have the trophies or the fame. But he still had his own life. And that had to be enough.

He didn't have Phainon's life, didn't have the things that seemed to come so easily to him—relationships, purpose, the certainty of his place in the world. But he still had his own life, even if it felt like a shadow of what it once could've been. And for now, that would have to be enough.

Mydei walked into the coffee shop, the familiar jingle of the doorbell above his head a soft reminder that, despite everything, life still moved forward, unbothered. He ordered his coffee quickly—black, nothing special—and

found a seat near the window, his body feeling a little more heavy than usual.

The familiar ache in his knee was there, just under the surface, lurking like a quiet reminder that it was always going to be part of him now. He shifted his weight, trying to ease the discomfort that flared up whenever he'd been standing too long. Years of physical therapy had given him back some of what he'd lost, but no amount of time or exercise could fully erase the damage. He knew his limits now—knew the exact moment when he'd push too far and his knee would retaliate.

As he sat down, he shifted his leg carefully, keeping it at an angle that minimized the strain. His right knee had never quite been the same. It wasn't just the pain anymore—it was the instability. His leg didn't always feel secure when he walked, a strange sense that it could give out if he wasn't careful. It was more of a dull, persistent discomfort now, like a reminder that his body had been changed forever.

Even after all the therapy, the strengthening exercises, and the months spent working to get back to some semblance of normal, there were still days when the hurt would rear its head. Some mornings, getting out of bed felt like lifting weights instead of just his legs. Some steps still caused his knee to lock up unexpectedly, forcing him to pause and breathe through the shock of it. He hated that, hated how it could still stop him in his tracks.

But now, it wasn't as jarring. It had become part of the background noise of his life, the constant hum of his injury, the thing that reminded him that he wasn't the person he used to be. And though he hated it, he also didn't know what else to do. It was just a fact. A part of him. It had been years, and he still couldn't quite accept it.

Mydei leaned back in his chair, sighing, trying to ignore the slow throb that spread up his leg. He had gotten used to this. Used to the adjustments. But still, in moments like this—when the stillness of the coffee shop surrounded him, and he had time to think—his mind wandered.

He wouldn't be able to play again. That was the reality. No more matches, no more late-night training sessions, no more feeling the ball beneath his

feet as he slid across the field, muscles working in harmony. All of that was gone, and no amount of physical therapy or medication would bring it back.

For a second, he wondered if that part of his life would ever really leave him. Would he always miss it? Would he always feel the gap where soccer used to be? Well whatever he felt, it wouldn't matter anymore.

Mydei took a sip of his coffee, the bitter warmth easing the ache in his chest more than the pain in his leg. He pulled his phone out, scrolling absently through the screen to check his schedule.

A few emails from old teammates, one or two from the physical therapy clinic he still visited on occasion, even though the need for it was less frequent now. He had his regular check-in appointments, routine follow-ups, and the occasional guest appearance for a charity game or soccer camp. But none of that took up much of his time anymore, not compared to the career he used to have.

He was a coach now. Part-time, more or less. He had taken on a few younger players in a local academy, helping them with drills, refining their technique, and guiding them through the mental game of soccer. It wasn't the thrill of competition, but it was fulfilling in its way. He enjoyed the coaching, the way he could still teach the things he'd learned over the years, even if he couldn't demonstrate them like he used to.

His day off today meant he didn't have to worry about the kids or any of the academy's morning sessions. It was a rare day where he had some time to himself, where he wasn't running between appointments or putting on a smile for cameras. The quiet felt almost too spacious at times, like the echo of a life that used to be busier, more full of noise.

Still, he liked this routine—enough to make it his own. He glanced at the calendar again, noting a few calls he needed to make later, some paperwork for the academy that had been left undone, and maybe a trip to the gym to keep his leg strong. The gym was where he still found a lot of his focus, even if it was more about managing his injury now than it had ever been about strength. The mirror in front of him reminded him of that every time he stepped onto the treadmill or took up some light weights.

Checking his phone, he saw a text from his assistant at the academy, a reminder about an upcoming youth match he had to attend next weekend. Mydei typed back a quick acknowledgment, then set his phone down with a sigh. The rest of his day? It would be filled with random errands, a little bit of solitude, and maybe even some aimless wandering through town.

A life not bad. But still—empty in some ways.

Mydei glanced out the window, watching the pedestrians pass by as the wind ruffled the leaves of nearby trees. The world still turned outside his bubble, moving on as it always did. He envied the ease with which people moved through their day, unaware of the weight of the past on his shoulders.

His gaze flickered to the corner of the shop where an older couple sat, holding hands, talking softly. His thoughts wandered back, just for a moment, to Phainon—how he'd always carried such effortless grace, whether he was on the field or off it.

But Mydei quickly shook his head, forcing the thoughts away.

He had enough to focus on. And at least today, it was his own life he could control, even if it wasn't exactly what he had imagined.

Phainon's schedule was a whirlwind of activity. Mydei knew that much, even without needing to look up his itinerary. He could practically track his movements by the headlines that seemed to follow him everywhere—constant updates about his next match, the interviews, the fans, the endless demands from the media. Phainon was a star in every sense of the word, his face plastered on billboards, his name synonymous with success in every country he played.

Every time Mydei opened his phone, he'd find another article, another photo, another headline marking Phainon's latest achievement—another championship win, another international tournament conquered. Phainon had become the face of global soccer, his feet carrying him across continents, winning titles, and breaking records. Every new trophy added to

his collection felt like a subtle reminder of the distance between them—how far Phainon had gone and how firmly Mydei had been left behind.

There were days when Mydei couldn't help but scroll through Phainon's posts on social media, his fingers brushing the screen as Phainon posed with fans, celebrated with teammates, or simply enjoyed moments of rare peace. He could see the joy in Phainon's eyes in every photo. It was the kind of happiness that was almost tangible, and Mydei couldn't deny how much he wished he could be a part of that world again. But even if he was, it wouldn't be the same. Phainon had Cyrene now, and that bond was stronger than anything Mydei could offer.

The envy stung, but he knew better than to dwell on it. He didn't want to be that person, the one who still pined for something that wasn't there anymore. Phainon was moving forward, and Mydei had to do the same. But it wasn't always that easy.

Even now, as he sat in the coffee shop, Phainon's latest match played in his mind. He had seen the postgame interview—a brief, distracted moment where Phainon was asked about his performance. Phainon had answered with his usual modesty, never one to revel in personal praise, but the glint in his eyes was unmistakable. He was at the top of his game, and that alone should have been enough. It had to be.

Still, Mydei couldn't help but feel a quiet pounding every time he saw Phainon celebrate another victory. There was something about it—something about how effortlessly Phainon seemed to command the field, how everything seemed to come so naturally for him. It was hard not to think that maybe, if he were still playing, he could have been right there with Phainon, lifting those trophies, feeling the rush of victory together.

But that wasn't his reality anymore.

Mydei had long stopped checking the detailed stats of every game. It was too much, too painful. Instead, he kept a distance, scrolling past most of the posts about Phainon's travels or the endless streams of highlights. But even that couldn't stop the way his heart clenched whenever he'd catch glimpses of his former teammate's success.

He saw Phainon’s name pop up again—another championship. Another trophy. Another win for the history books. It felt like a constant reminder of what could have been, the person he might still be if things had gone differently.

Maybe Phainon didn’t need him anymore. Maybe he didn’t even want to be reminded of what they once had.

But Mydei couldn’t shake the thought. Every time Phainon posted a picture with Cyrene, every time he smiled that same bright, perfect smile Mydei remembered from their younger days on the field, it reminded him of what he missed. It reminded him of the connection they used to have, how it had felt like they were invincible, together.

He’d never been able to tell Phainon how much it had meant to him, how the friendship they had back then had kept him grounded when the pressure of being a professional athlete became too much. Maybe it had always been more than just friendship, but Mydei never allowed himself to go there. It was easier to pretend. Easier to convince himself that their closeness was just a phase.

But no matter how much he tried to suppress it, the yearning still lingered. He found himself waiting for the next moment when Phainon might reach out when he’d call or text just to catch up like they used to. It wasn’t much, but it was something. Something that kept Mydei tethered to him, even if only for a few seconds of conversation.

Still, Mydei couldn’t bring himself to reach out. Not now, not when he knew Phainon was so far removed from the world they used to share. He wasn’t ready to face the reality that, in many ways, they were strangers to each other now.

Well, not exactly…

Despite the distance between them, Phainon’s presence in Mydei’s life wasn’t as gone as he sometimes convinced himself. It wasn’t the loud, brash presence Phainon had when they were on the field together, not anymore. But it was still there, quietly, in the small ways Phainon reached out.

The first message came a few weeks after Mydei's last low point, the one where his leg had flared up again—too much stress, too many hours on his feet without enough rest. It wasn't a new injury, but the pain was enough to remind him that his body wasn't what it used to be. He'd been hoping to sleep it off, trying to ignore the ache that refused to subside.

But then, an alert on his phone broke through the stillness.

"How's your leg today? Let me know if you need anything."

It was from Phainon. Just a simple message. Nothing extravagant. But Mydei couldn't help but stop for a moment, fingers hovering over the screen as he reread the words. Phainon still cared. After everything, after the years and the silence between them, he still took the time to check-in.

It wasn't just the occasional message like this. Sometimes, Phainon would text after big games, a quick "We won tonight, and I was thinking about you," or even a more casual "How's life treating you these days?" They were small gestures, moments that kept the distance from feeling like too much. Phainon wasn't oblivious to Mydei's absence. He hadn't forgotten him, even if they hadn't seen each other in a while.

And that was what kept Mydei clinging to the past. It wasn't the idea of their friendship returning to what it was—it was the feeling of being seen, even from afar.

Phainon reached out when he could. He always did. It wasn't the kind of connection Mydei longed for, but it was something. It was a lifeline, keeping Mydei grounded when the weight of missing Phainon threatened to crush him.

The invitations to watch games were a regular occurrence, too. Sometimes Phainon would send him tickets to matches in the cities he was visiting, hoping to see him in the stands. Phainon knew he couldn't come every time, but the offer was always there. He knew Mydei wasn't in the same position anymore, and wasn't physically able to play or keep up with the fast-paced life of professional soccer. But he still made the effort and still tried to keep him in the loop.

A few weeks ago, there had even been a more personal moment—a late-night call from Phainon, his voice soft and apologetic. “I heard you had a rough day. Wanted to check in. Need anything?”

Mydei had almost laughed at the simplicity of it, at how Phainon had always been this way—caring, present in his quiet way, even if it didn’t look like the romantic gestures Mydei wished for. It wasn’t a declaration of anything, wasn’t a confession of longing or desire. It was just… Phainon, being Phainon. Always there, even when the connection between them felt distant, even when the world seemed to separate them more with every passing day.

It hurt, of course. The kind of care Phainon offered was never the kind Mydei wanted. It wasn’t that kind of affection, the kind that could pull him close again, the kind that would make him believe Phainon might see him as more than just an old teammate. But in his heart, Mydei cherished it all the same, even when he knew it wasn’t enough.

Still, he couldn’t ignore the pull he felt when he read those words when he saw Phainon’s name flashing on his screen. There was something undeniably comforting in the knowledge that Phainon hadn’t shut him out entirely, even if their worlds had shifted in ways Mydei wasn’t prepared to face.

And yet, as much as he tried to move past it, the longing remained. Phainon was still there—still checking in, still offering his quiet brand of care—but it wasn’t enough. Mydei couldn’t help but wonder, with every message, every check-in, if it could be more.

The café had emptied a little by the time Mydei was finishing his coffee, the morning rush fading into a quiet lull. His phone sat facedown on the table, notifications flickering at the edge of his vision, but he wasn’t in the mood to check them. Not yet.

He exhaled, stretching his leg out beneath the table with practiced caution, testing the stiffness in his knee. Not terrible today. He’d been moving more carefully lately, avoiding anything that would send a sharp reminder of his limits. The last thing he needed was another flare-up.

Just as he was about to stand, his phone vibrated, the sudden buzz against the wooden table breaking his focus. With a sigh, he flipped it over.

A message from an old teammate. “Damn, remember this?”

Beneath it, is a link to a video.

He clicked it without thinking, and suddenly, the past was playing out in front of him.

A match from years ago— him and Phainon, side by side on the field. The camera panned as they sprinted down the pitch together, Mydei breaking through defenders with effortless speed while Phainon set up for the perfect assist. It was muscle memory between them, the kind of instinct that only came from years of playing together. Phainon didn’t even need to look to know exactly where Mydei would be. A smooth pass, a feint past the keeper, and then— goal.

The crowd erupted, the video cutting to the celebration. Mydei remembered this match. They had won.

He watched as the camera lingered on Phainon. While the rest of the team was celebrating, Phainon’s eyes had been elsewhere—watching Mydei. Just for a second, a flicker of something unreadable crossed his face. Nostalgia? Maybe.

But before Mydei could overanalyze it, the clip ended, replaced by the cold, empty screen of his phone.

He sat there for a moment, fingers hovering over the keyboard. He could reply. Say something casual, laugh it off, pretend it didn’t hit quite as deep as it did. But instead, he locked his phone and pushed back his chair.

He had a physical therapy appointment today. Routine checkup. He’d been keeping up with his exercises, doing everything the doctors recommended, but these visits were a reminder of the gap between the past and the present.

Grabbing his jacket, he slung it over one shoulder and stepped out of the café, his mind still replaying that moment in the video.

Phainon had looked back.

That shouldn’t have meant anything.

And yet, it did.

-

The clinic smelled like antiseptic and something faintly citrusy, the same as it always had. The air was cool, the hum of fluorescent lights blending with the occasional murmur of voices. Mydei signed in at the front desk with a practiced ease, the receptionist offering him a polite but disinterested nod before directing him to the waiting area.

He sat down, stretching his leg out carefully in front of him. His knee had started to stiffen on the walk over—nothing unbearable, just a quiet, familiar discomfort that never fully went away. He rolled his ankle absentmindedly, trying to ease the tension, his thoughts still lingering on the video.

The past didn’t belong here. Not in this clinic, not in the quiet, sterile space where progress was measured in degrees of flexibility and stability tests. And yet, it clung to him, the weight of old games and lost possibilities pressing against his ribs.

A few minutes later, a door opened, and a physical therapist he’d worked with before—Jules—glanced at the clipboard in his hands before looking up.

“Mydei,” Jules greeted, giving him a small nod. “Come on back.”

He followed Jules into one of the exam rooms, settling onto the table as the other man pulled up a stool.

“How’s the knee been?” Jules asked, flipping through his notes.

Mydei shrugged. “Same as usual. No major pain unless I push it too much.”

Jules hummed, setting the clipboard down. “Any instability? Locking?”

“Not really. It gets stiff, but nothing serious.”

“Good. Let’s check things out.”

Mydei had been through this routine more times than he could count. He let Jules guide his leg through the motions—bending, extending, pressing against resistance. It wasn’t painful, but it wasn’t smooth either. His knee would never be what it once was. That was just a fact.

Jules must have noticed something in his expression because he exhaled through his nose, setting Mydei’s leg back down.

“You’re doing fine,” Jules said. “Better than most, honestly. A lot of guys with an injury like yours end up in worse shape.”

Mydei huffed a quiet laugh. “Comforting.”

Jules gave him a look. “You know what I mean.”

Yeah, he did. But it didn’t make it any less frustrating.

Jules made a few more notes, then leaned back. “Are you still keeping up with your routine? Strength training, mobility work?”

“Yeah.” Mydei ran a hand through his hair. “It’s just… slower now.”

“That’s normal.” Jules studied him for a moment before adding, “You’re not thinking about pushing yourself too hard, are you?”

“No.” The answer came automatically, but Jules didn’t look convinced.

“Mydei.”

He sighed, rubbing his jaw. “I know my limits.”

“Just making sure.” Jules closed the folder. “I don’t need you showing up here in worse shape because you decided to prove something to yourself.”

There was nothing to prove. Not anymore.

Jules stood, stretching his arms above his head. “Alright, you’re good to go. Keep up with what you’re doing, and let me know if anything changes.”

Mydei nodded, slipping off the table. His knee twitched faintly as he stood, but he ignored it.

As he left the clinic, stepping back into the afternoon light, he exhaled slowly.

One more checkup is done. Another reminder of what he’d lost.

And still, his thoughts drifted back to the video.

Phainon had looked back.

Why did that matter so much?

Mydei wasn’t one for a lot of talking at the gym. It was just him, his headphones, and the constant hum of gym equipment. It was familiar, grounding. He walked in through the glass doors, the air thick with the smell of rubber mats and the metallic tang of weights being lifted.

His knee still ached from the clinic visit, but he had long learned to block that out when he needed to. Instead, he focused on his arms—the one area of his body that hadn’t lost its power after the injury. The leg was a different story, of course. That would never be the same. But the rest of him? That he could control. That he could make stronger.

The bench press was first. He gripped the barbell with ease, adjusting his position and planting his feet firmly on the ground. He lowered the bar to his chest with fluid precision, pushing it back up, the repetition steady and

familiar. The muscles in his arms, shoulders, and chest burned with each press, and for a moment, he could almost forget about the knee that had ruined everything.

His left leg wasn't as strong as it had once been, so he had learned to compensate by focusing on other parts of his body. He had swapped out leg-heavy exercises for more upper-body work, targeting his arms and core, areas that had always been strong but now needed extra attention. He had his routine down to an art now, carefully constructed to avoid aggravating the injury but still push his body as much as it could go.

There were days when the pain in his knee was a constant, nagging reminder of what had been taken from him. But then there were days like today—days when he felt strong when the rhythm of the weights in his hands and the sweat on his skin made him forget for a while. Forget that his professional career was over and that he would never feel the rush of competition again.

After a few more sets, he wiped his face with the back of his hand, taking a deep breath. He glanced around the gym, the low chatter of other people working out in the background. His gaze flickered over to the far side of the room, where a few younger athletes were running drills. They had that energy—the kind he used to have. The kind that made him feel invincible.

But that was a different life. A life that didn't exist anymore.

He threw his towel over his shoulder, moving to the stretching area to work out his leg. His knee was still stiff from earlier, so he focused on slow, controlled movements, trying to push through the discomfort. He kept his mind busy, not wanting to linger too much on the physical reminder of what he'd lost, but the thoughts always crept back in.

His phone buzzed in his pocket, pulling him out of his thoughts. He ignored it at first, trying to focus on his stretches, but it buzzed again, this time with an urgent little jolt.

He reached for it, checking the screen.

A text from Phainon.

Mydei opened the message, his thumb hovering over the screen as he read it again, just to make sure his eyes weren't playing tricks on him.

Hey, Mydei. I'm visiting your country for a gaming event in New York soon. When I get some free time, I'll come by and visit you. ^ ᵕ ^ ~"

The little emoticon at the end made his heart flutter. There it was again, that softness from Phainon—so sweet, so genuine like nothing had changed between them. Mydei stared at the message for a long time, the air around him suddenly feeling too thick. Phainon was coming to New York. To visit him. He couldn't stop the rush of warmth that filled his chest.

But with that warmth came a spike of anxiety. He could barely breathe, his fingers trembling as he gripped his phone. This wasn't just a casual "Hey, how's it going?" message. This was… different. This was Phainon coming here. To see him.

And then, before he had a chance to gather his thoughts, another message popped up.

If you want to come, I can send you a flight. Let me know. I'll make sure it fits into my schedule.

The offer was sudden, but there it was. Phainon, offering him a flight. Phainon, who was always so busy with tournaments, with games, with his own life—Phainon was offering to take the time to bring Mydei to New York to see him.

Mydei's heart stuttered in his chest. He hadn't expected that, had never even imagined it would be an option. He sat frozen for a few seconds, reading the message again, his mind whirling.

The thought of seeing Phainon again, of being close to him like they used to be, felt like a distant dream. But this wasn't a dream. This was real, and it was happening.

He quickly set his phone down, trying to regain some semblance of control over his racing thoughts. His heart was pounding, the beat almost deafening in his ears as his mind flipped between excitement and uncertainty. What did it mean that Phainon wanted him there? What was Phainon offering?

But it was already too late. Mydei's fingers had moved before he could fully think it through. The flight booking app opened, and without hesitation, he selected a ticket.

New York. To see Phainon. His heart was still in his throat as he clicked the confirm button, not really sure how he felt about it but knowing, deep down, that he couldn't turn back now. This was happening. Phainon was coming, and so was he.

A few seconds later, the confirmation screen popped up, and Mydei stared at it, unsure of what he felt, but one thing was certain—he was about to be face-to-face with Phainon again. After all this time.

A few seconds later, the confirmation screen popped up, and Mydei stared at it, unsure of what he felt, but one thing was certain—he was about to be face-to-face with Phainon again. After all this time.

His thumb hovered over the screen, about to drop the phone back into his bag. Then, in a rush, he realized he hadn't responded to Phainon's offer yet. He quickly opened the thread again and typed out a simple reply:

"It's fine. I can do it. Thanks, Phainon."

The message was sent before he could second-guess himself. He glanced at it for a moment, wondering if he'd said the right thing. But just as he was about to shove his phone into his gym bag, the weight of his decision crashed into him.

"Oh, fuck."

He'd booked the flight. He was going to New York to see Phainon. But he hadn't thought this through. First of all, his leg. He'd been managing fine without a knee brace for the most part, but he couldn't exactly ignore the

fact that he might need more than just painkillers and a quick stretch for this trip. The flight was long, and sitting in a cramped economy seat for hours was going to be a nightmare. He should've booked first class. Hell, maybe even premium economy . Anything to make this easier on his body. But now it was too late.

And then, the logistics. Mydei let out a heavy sigh, leaning against the nearby weight rack. He had to wrap up his work here in Texas—cancel a few appointments, move around some things with his new job, and deal with any potential follow-ups. It wasn't just a quick escape. It wasn't as simple as packing a bag and hopping on a plane. He was about to leave for a completely different state, one with its own set of challenges, and that meant managing everything back here.

His heart started to race. He was already feeling overwhelmed, already doubting his decision. What the hell was he doing?

This wasn't a spontaneous vacation. This was Phainon—someone he hadn't seen in years. Someone who had moved on with his life, who had other people in it now. Mydei was about to just… show up. He could pick up where they left off when things had never really ended the way they should have.

What if this was a huge mistake?

"What the fuck am I even doing?" Mydei muttered to himself, taking a shaky breath. He glanced at the gym clock, forcing himself to focus on something else, but his thoughts were spiraling. He'd been living in this routine for years now—pain, physical therapy, the quiet hum of his day-to-day existence—and now he was about to throw himself into the unknown again.

Still, he had already made the decision. And he couldn't go back. Not now.

For the next week, Mydei worked like a man possessed. He hadn't known what he was doing when he booked the flight—what kind of chaos he was about to throw himself into—but now there was no turning back. Every free moment was spent rearranging appointments, rescheduling meetings, and

handling everything he'd been putting off. He'd been in the groove of his routine for so long that stepping outside of it felt jarring. But he'd made the choice. He had to follow through.

He made sure to get everything set up for the flight, contacting the airline for accommodations, making sure they could offer him extra space for his leg, and getting a seat with proper support. It felt like an ordeal, but at least he wasn't about to be crammed into an economy seat without room to stretch his leg out. Even with those minor arrangements, he found himself stressed. Then came arranging things for New York. He booked a hotel that was close enough to where Phainon's event was but also had easy access to medical care if anything went wrong with his knee. Every decision had to be thought through, every plan made, just in case.

By the time the day of the flight arrived, Mydei was exhausted. But there he was, standing in the airport with his bag in hand, staring blankly ahead. His thoughts swirled in a chaotic storm, too fast for him to catch or hold onto. How had he gotten here?

He could still hear Phainon's message in his head, the cute emoticon he'd sent. He could almost feel the excitement in it, the subtle warmth that hinted at a welcome. But no matter how much time he spent trying to calm himself, trying to center his mind, he couldn't ignore the nervous tension building in his chest. What was he doing? Was he going to face Phainon again, after all this time?

He exhaled slowly, running a hand through his hair, feeling a bit detached from everything happening around him. Maybe this wasn't a mistake. But the fear was there. The overwhelming pressure of everything that came with this sudden trip. He had no idea what to expect. But in that moment, all he could do was keep moving forward.

With a sigh, he stepped forward toward the gate, shaking off the creeping doubts. He was on his way. And he would figure the rest out when he got there.

The flight itself was a blur. Between the discomfort of his leg and the general exhaustion of the past week, Mydei barely remembered the takeoff

or the flight attendants making their rounds. His leg, wrapped in a brace and propped up as best as he could manage, throbbed with every movement, but he tried not to let it dominate his thoughts. He'd checked and rechecked everything—his medical supplies, the accommodations, his phone—but nothing seemed to calm the unease that had settled deep in his chest.

When the plane finally touched down in New York, Mydei was beyond relieved. The moment he stepped off the plane, he felt a rush of fresh air hit him, sharp and cold, a sharp contrast to the stale recirculated air on the plane. He pulled up his collar, taking in the busy energy of the airport, the blur of faces and rushing bodies all around him.

His first stop was to get his bag, the weight of it a reminder that he had made this trip. He tried to push past the residual doubt that lingered from the moment he first bought the ticket, focusing on the small victories. His bag was in hand, his leg was still sore but manageable, and he had everything he needed to get through the next few days.

Mydei hadn't been to New York in years. The city, always bustling with life, felt slightly foreign now. He found his way to the car service area outside the airport. He wasn't about to deal with a public taxi; not with his leg. Instead, he'd pre-arranged a ride, and soon enough, a sleek black car pulled up in front of him. The driver, a friendly woman with short blonde hair and a warm smile, greeted him as he got in.

The ride was smooth, the city's skyline beginning to emerge in the distance, rising in the night like some dream of possibility. The lights of the streets, the hum of distant conversations—it all felt so… overwhelming. A part of him still couldn't believe he was here, about to see Phainon after all these years.

It took about an hour to get to his hotel, and by the time they arrived, Mydei could barely keep his eyes open. He paid the driver, grabbed his bag, and stumbled inside to the front desk.

The check-in process felt like it took a lifetime. The receptionist, cheerful as ever, handed him the room key with a quick "Enjoy your stay!" Mydei

could barely process her words as he nodded, mumbling a thanks. He moved sluggishly toward the elevator, desperate to get to his room.

When he finally got to the room, he shut the door behind him, collapsed onto the bed, and groaned as his tired body sank into the soft mattress. The exhaustion from the last week, the tension of the flight, and the buildup of everything that had led him to this moment hit him all at once.

Before he even had the chance to change out of his clothes, he was out, face first into the pillows. His body screamed for rest, and for once, he didn't hesitate.

The bed swallowed him whole, and he let it. God forbid he gets any rest for once.

-

When Mydei woke up the next morning, the soreness in his knee was there, a constant hum beneath his skin, but it wasn't anything new. After a quick stretch, he let out a slow breath, letting the slight pain pass over him as he sat up on the edge of the bed. The day ahead would be a welcome distraction.

He went for a long bath, letting the warm water soak into his muscles. The jet bubbles helped ease the tightness in his legs, the lingering tension in his body reminding him of just how much he'd pushed himself in the last week. He wasn't used to traveling this much anymore, or being away for extended periods. It had been a long time since his last trip anywhere this far.

But now, New York. A new place, a new chance to reconnect, if only for a short while. The anticipation started to build up again, like a weight inside his chest that he couldn't shake. But for now, it was a welcome distraction. He had a day or two before the games, time to explore, to get some air, to

forget the knot of emotions that had been tugging at him since the moment he booked his flight.

After drying off and dressing casually—nothing too flashy, just comfortable enough for walking around—he left his hotel room, stepping out into the city's bustling streets. The streets of New York felt alive in a way that only a place like this could. There were cars everywhere, people rushing by, some tourists with cameras, others with a purpose. The sound of the city—a constant, vibrant buzz—wrapped around him, pulling him into its rhythm.

He didn't have a destination in mind, but he wanted to feel the pulse of the city, even if just for a few hours. As he wandered, his mind kept drifting back to the text messages, to the idea of Phainon being close. So close. He tried not to think too much about it. But everything about this felt like a step into something he wasn't sure he was ready for.

His knee didn't bother him much while he walked—just the occasional stiff step to remind him that it'd never be the same again. But he didn't care. He was used to it. The soft tap of his sneakers against the pavement was grounding, a reminder that he was still here, still moving.

Mydei wandered through Fifth Avenue, the overwhelming bustle of the city slowly blending into the background. It was a different pace than what he was used to, a little more chaotic, a little less predictable, but it wasn't entirely unpleasant. As he walked past the windows of high-end shops, his mind seemed to wander, distracted by the bright lights and flashy displays.

He hadn't come here for anything specific—just to get out of the hotel for a bit, and clear his head. But when his eyes landed on a familiar face on a billboard, something inside him froze.

Mydei's steps slowed as he passed the advertisement, the colors of the poster standing out starkly even against the brighter tones of the city street. Cyrene and Phainon—there they were again, grinning like the world was theirs, a perfect pair captured in a moment of pure joy. He quickly shifted his gaze, feeling a knot tighten in his chest.

He wasn’t jealous. Not really. He couldn’t be—not when Cyrene was the kind of person who made everyone around her feel welcome, who had a lightness to her that was rare to find. She was easy to like, and Phainon had always been protective of her. Childhood friends, sure. But now they were more than that, and Mydei was honestly happy for both of them. His thoughts, however, always tangled up in some strange way when it came to them.

Mydei turned the corner and continued down the street, the brief discomfort already starting to fade. He was used to these little twinges of envy. He just didn’t let them fester.

Lately, though, it seemed to be happening more often, especially when he thought about the kids. He didn’t even know how it had started. A few of his friends had kids, and while he wasn’t the first person to volunteer for babysitting duty, he’d somehow ended up with it. Maybe it was because they trusted him? Or maybe it was just his general lack of a social life that led to him being the go-to babysitter when someone needed a last-minute favor.

Either way, he’d taken to spending random afternoons watching over toddlers or helping out with school pickups. It wasn’t bad, but Mydei was never quite sure what to do with them. They were noisy, energetic little creatures with more questions than he could answer, but there was something about their carefree nature that made him smile. The way they didn’t expect anything from him—no expectations, no weighty conversations, just their laughter and bright eyes.

Sometimes, when he was left alone with them, he’d catch himself missing them more than he wanted to admit.

“Just don’t touch anything, alright?” he muttered to himself with a small smile, thinking of the last time one of the kids had tried to rearrange his entire bookshelf, while the other one had insisted on telling him about some random drawing they’d made at school. He wasn’t sure why, but those little moments had stuck with him. He guessed he was getting soft.

Now, here he was in New York, about to cross through the doors of a fancy store where all the prices made his stomach flip *(Yes he was loaded with all the money he made off previous games and the reimbursement, but he was still financially responsible, ok?)* and yet he couldn't stop thinking about picking up a few trinkets for the kids. Maybe they didn't need anything, but the idea of bringing them back something seemed… right. Something he could do for them to make up for all the times they'd gotten on his nerves, even if he wasn't sure they'd care for the souvenirs.

But that was just the kind of person he was now, wasn't it? Softer, and a bit more caring than he'd like to admit.

By the time Mydei had finished his shopping, the sky was starting to darken, and the streets were buzzing with the evening crowd. He had picked up a few things—a couple of souvenirs for the kids he babysat from time to time and some random trinkets that felt right in the moment.

His shoulders relaxed as he stepped out of the store, the weight of the bags comforting, but the exhaustion from walking all day setting in. He was ready to head back to the hotel, maybe grab something to eat, and just decompress before the games started.

As he walked through the busy streets, weaving through groups of people, he spotted a small crowd gathered around someone near a sidewalk vendor. It only took a second for him to realize it was one of Phainon's teammates. He wasn't sure of the guy's name, but the jersey was enough of a giveaway. The crowd was taking photos, cheering, talking to him—it was just another scene he didn't care to be a part of.

He glanced at the group, noted the camera flashes, and immediately turned away, walking briskly down another street. The last thing he wanted to deal with right now was some random encounter with a player, or worse, getting caught up in another group of fans who might recognize him. He just needed some space.

But as he continued to walk, he realized something was off. The streets all started to look the same, and before he knew it, he'd somehow taken a

wrong turn. Now, instead of being on his way back to the hotel, he was standing on an unfamiliar block, with no idea where to go.

“Great,” Mydei muttered under his breath, scanning the street signs. Nothing was familiar, and he could already feel the frustration bubbling up.

His hand instinctively went to his pocket to check his phone, but when he pulled it out, he saw the battery was dead. Perfect. Of course, it was. He couldn’t remember the last time he’d charged it.

“Well, that’s just fantastic,” he sighed, rubbing a hand over his face. The last thing he wanted was to wander around New York with no phone, no directions, and no clue where the hell he was.

He took a deep breath, trying to steady himself. It wasn’t the end of the world. He could figure this out. But as the evening grew darker, the reality of being lost in a city that felt far too big started to sink in.

Mydei stood frozen for a moment, the frustration bubbling up inside him as his ankle pounded from the awkward turn he’d taken earlier. He had no choice now but to ask for help—he couldn’t keep walking around in circles, risking getting even more lost.

He gritted his teeth, steeling himself, and scanned the small crowd nearby. There was a group of people chatting by a street corner. They looked friendly enough. He took a deep breath, squaring his shoulders before heading toward them.

But then something caught his eye. A girl, her head down, wearing a hoodie pulled so low it almost covered her face. She was walking quickly, her body language almost too intentional—like she was trying to stay unnoticed. Mydei’s eyes narrowed slightly as he instinctively stepped aside, but then, in a sudden misstep, her foot caught on the uneven pavement.

Without thinking, his arms shot out to steady her, just as she started to lose her balance. His ankle screamed in protest, a sharp, familiar pain shooting up his leg, but he ignored it, focusing on catching her before she fell.

The girl stumbled, and Mydei instinctively held her up, feeling her weight for just a second before he helped her steady herself.

She blinked, looking up in surprise—and then Mydei froze.

For a moment, all he could do was stare. The girl in his arms was none other than Cyrene. The hoodie, the careful steps—she was hiding from something, from someone, but here she was, right in front of him, after all this time.

“Cyrene?” Mydei’s voice caught in his throat, and he quickly pulled his hands away, stepping back awkwardly.

She looked up at him, her expression melting into something familiar—wide eyes, a hint of surprise, and then a smile. “Mydei?” Her voice was full of warmth, and the way she said his name made everything seem a little less heavy like time had somehow skipped over all the awkwardness and tension.

A burst of emotion hit Mydei. Guilt, mostly. How long had it been since they last saw each other? He had kept his distance, kept to himself, his insecurities turning into a wall between him and everyone. And now, here she was—someone who had always been there, even when he hadn’t wanted to admit it.

“It’s… it’s been a while,” Mydei finally managed, his voice a little rougher than he intended. He tried to force a smile but felt it fall flat.

Cyrene’s smile never wavered. “It has. I’m happy to see you, though. How are you? Still up to your usual things?” She asked the question casually, as though there hadn’t been any distance between them, as if no time had passed.

Mydei hesitated for a moment before answering. “I’m… good. Better than before,” he muttered, his mind flicking back to his knee, the reminders of everything he used to be. “You?”

She tilted her head, clearly sensing something unspoken in his tone, but she didn’t push. “I’m great. But I didn’t expect to run into you here of all places. Fancy seeing you in New York!”

Mydei was silent for a moment, a wave of guilt pressing against his chest. His mind flashed to those times—times he should have reached out, should have been better to her. Instead, he’d let jealousy of her relationship with Phainon cloud his thoughts. What the hell had he been doing?

Cyrene caught his eye, her smile gentle, her tone unaffected by the years of distance between them. “You know,” she said, lowering her hood slightly, “I’m glad you’re still around, Mydei. Glad.” She didn’t say it like she was trying to make him feel better; she just meant it, and somehow, that made everything inside him feel a little lighter.

A heavy sigh slipped past Mydei’s lips. He wasn’t sure why he had felt the need to push everyone away all this time. With Cyrene, it felt like there was no need for any of the walls he’d built up.

“Phainon and I were just talking about you the other day,” she added casually, unaware of the way her words caused Mydei’s chest to tighten. He couldn’t help it, but hearing that brought all his old insecurities to the surface again.

He opened his mouth to say something, but the words didn’t come out right. Instead, he found himself muttering, “I should have… I should’ve reached out sooner.”

Cyrene’s smile softened, and she placed a hand on his shoulder, squeezing gently. “It’s alright. Things happen. We’re here now, though. And I’m glad you’re still here.”

Mydei’s heart twisted. How had he ever let jealousy cloud things with her? Cyrene was nothing but kind, and here he was, worried about things that didn’t matter. Maybe it wasn’t too late to start being better.

“Let’s get some coffee,” Cyrene said, her voice light. “I could use the company.”

Mydei hesitated, his internal conflict still fresh in his mind, but her genuine kindness won out. “Yeah, okay. Let’s go.”

After they ordered their coffee, Cyrene led them to a small corner table in the café, the quiet hum of conversation in the background a nice contrast to the frantic energy of the city outside. Mydei took a sip of his drink, the warmth spreading through him, and felt a strange sense of peace as they sat there.

It had been a while since he’d felt so comfortable in someone else’s company. The conversation was easy—and lighthearted. They talked about old memories from when they’d played together, Cyrene’s latest training routines, and even a bit about Phainon, though Mydei kept his answers vague, trying not to let his discomfort show.

Cyrene smiled, leaning back in her seat. “You’re looking good, Mydei. Really. I didn’t expect to see you looking so… well, at peace.” Her eyes twinkled, and Mydei could see the genuine warmth in her expression, a kindness he hadn’t realized he’d missed so much.

He shrugged, trying not to let himself feel too seen. “I’ve been keeping busy,” he said simply, avoiding the weight of the words he’d wanted to say. He didn’t want to get into the details of his injury or how he’d been holding himself together. There was no need. Not with Cyrene.

He glanced at his phone, to which Cyrene had given him a charger for when they’d got here, remembering that he hadn’t responded to Phainon’s messages yet. He’d promised to let him know when he arrived, and somehow—*somehow*—he had forgotten. It wasn’t like Phainon would expect much, but Mydei knew the small gestures mattered.

He reached for his phone, tapping on it absentmindedly as he kept up the conversation. Cyrene was recounting a funny moment from a match she’d been in, but Mydei’s mind was elsewhere. His thumb swiped over the screen to Phainon’s message, but before he could reply, his gaze landed on the time.

It was already late. And then, something else caught his attention. His hotel.

His stomach dropped.

He had asked for just one night. One. And that was it. The system had auto-checked him out earlier in the day.

“What the hell?” Mydei muttered under his breath, suddenly feeling a knot tighten in his chest. He could feel the panic beginning to creep in, but he didn’t let it show. Not to Cyrene.

“Everything okay?” Cyrene asked, her voice soft with concern, noticing his shift in demeanor.

“Yeah, yeah,” Mydei said, a little too quickly. “Just… forgot to message Phainon. You know how it is.”

Cyrene didn’t press, letting him off the hook with just a smile. “I’m sure he’ll understand. You’ll catch up later.”

“Yeah,” Mydei murmured, clicking his tongue as he set the phone down, trying to focus on the conversation again. But his mind was still on the hotel situation. He had to figure something out fast, without putting too much strain on his leg.

His phone buzzed in his pocket, and he glanced at it quickly to see an alert about the hotel checkout. No help there.

In his head, he was already running through options: call a car, drag his ass across the city to the hotel to grab his things, then find another place, probably at the last minute, in the chaos of New York. Or he could find something local… something closer… but the thought of navigating that with his leg, his exhaustion, made him groan quietly.

He shoved the worry to the back of his mind for the moment, focusing on Cyrene as she rambled on about one of the team’s recruits. It felt good to leave the stress behind for a few minutes. She always had a way of making things seem lighter, even if it was just for a little while. There was no use in making things worse.

After Cyrene excused herself and headed off to her next task, Mydei took a moment to collect his things. His bag slung over his shoulder, he mentally prepared himself for the next step—finding somewhere to stay. But when he started checking hotels, a sinking realization hit him.

Every place in the city was overbooked. It seemed like the whole world had descended on New York to watch the game. No surprise, considering Phainon's star power. Mydei, too stubborn to give up, tried to look for alternatives, but time passed, and the search seemed endless. Eventually, defeated, he dropped his bag down on the nearest bench, rubbing his temples. What the hell was he even doing here?

With a sigh, he fished out his phone, mindlessly scrolling. The streets of New York were as busy as ever, and his thoughts were heavy, his stomach an odd mix of excitement and dread. Amid his thoughts, he hesitated for a moment, then decided to do something he hadn't in a while: he called Phainon.

It rang a few times before Phainon's voice finally came through, sounding lighter than Mydei expected, as though the chaos of the game hadn't caught up to him just yet.

"Look who's calling. I figured you'd finally cave and reach out," Phainon said with a teasing tone.

Mydei couldn't help but roll his eyes, though a slight grin tugged at the corner of his lips. "I needed something to distract me. Seems like I've got plenty of time to kill in this damn city."

Phainon chuckled. "I hear that. New York's got a way of swallowing people whole. What's up?"

"Just… trying to get a grip on this place." Mydei shrugged, even though Phainon couldn't see it. "Everything's either packed or overpriced. Not much room left for me."

"Sounds like fun," Phainon teased. "Well, you could've booked a room with me. I told you before—I've got a whole hotel suite with space to spare."

“Don’t think you’re getting off that easy,” Mydei said flatly. “I don’t need to sleep next to your ego.”

“Now, that’s cold. I could’ve given you the best bed in the place.” Phainon chuckled again, but there was something softer behind it. “You sure you’re alright though? I know traveling’s not exactly easy on you.”

“I’m fine,” Mydei said, his voice steady. “Just tired, that’s all.”

“Yeah, I bet. So, what’s the plan for tonight?” Phainon asked. “Found a spot yet? Or just sitting in some random corner like you always do?”

Mydei raised an eyebrow, though no one could see him. “Not exactly, but close enough.”

“Should’ve let me know when you were coming. I would’ve made time for you,” Phainon said lightly, and there was something in his tone that made Mydei’s heart skip a beat.

It took him a second to respond, words caught in his throat. His gaze drifted to the streetlights as he forced a nonchalant tone. “Well, I’m just here for the game, not to bother you.”

Phainon laughed, and it was just the right sound, warm and sincere. “You wouldn’t be bothering me. I’m serious. You should’ve let me know.”

Mydei felt his chest tighten. It was too easy to get lost in the sound of Phainon’s voice, but he quickly caught himself before he said anything too revealing. Instead, he shifted the conversation. “I ran into Cyrene today. It’s been a while since I saw her.”

“Oh?” Phainon’s voice was curious, surprised. “How’d that go?”

“It was fine,” Mydei said quickly. “She’s… good. I bumped into her on the street.”

Phainon seemed amused by the way Mydei phrased it. “Well, I’m glad you’re both doing okay. I’ve been hearing a lot about her lately.”

Mydei stayed quiet for a moment, feeling the weight of the conversation settle in. “Yeah,” he muttered, forcing the words out. “I should get going though.”

“Alright,” Phainon replied, his voice soft but teasing. “You better not be running off to avoid me. But hey, if you’re in the area tomorrow, let me know. We can catch up for real”

“No promises,” Mydei said with a smirk in his voice, his heart rate picking up somewhat.

They exchanged a few more words, light banter before the conversation came to an end. Mydei hung up, his thoughts still swirling around the call.

He didn’t even notice the rain until it started to hit his face, the cool droplets a sharp contrast to the warmth of the conversation. He sat there for a while longer, watching the rain blur the streetlights.

A small sigh left him. Maybe things weren’t as complicated as they seemed, but his heart still ached in a way he couldn’t shake.

The rain made everything harder. The wet pavement was slick beneath Mydei’s steps, and he had to slow down, forcing himself to plant his foot carefully with each movement. His knee had never been forgiving in conditions like this, the instability making itself known with every uneven surface.

A group of people hurried past him, their steps quick and sure, and he clenched his jaw, irritated at how easily they moved while he had to think about every step. The cold only made it worse. His knee was in bad shape, the familiar dull throb settling deep into the joint, but he ignored it, tightening his grip on the strap of his bag.

He just needed to get back.

The city lights reflected off the rain-slicked streets, everything blurring together in a haze of gold and red. He pushed forward, stepping onto a curb

a little too fast. His knee buckled slightly, and he caught himself before he could stumble, sucking in a sharp breath through his nose.

He exhaled slowly. Kept moving.

A couple under a shared umbrella passed by, the woman casting him a glance. Maybe she noticed the slight hitch in his step, or maybe he just looked as tired as he felt. Either way, Mydei didn't meet her gaze. He had nothing to say.

The rain wasn't letting up. His clothes were damp, his muscles tense from the cold, and the hotel situation was still unresolved. He sighed, rubbing a hand down his face. His phone was charged now—he could start looking for another place to stay, but the idea of moving around more, of dealing with the hassle of check-ins and crowded lobbies, made him want to sit down right where he stood.

His fingers flexed at his side. The conversation with Phainon still lingered in his mind, overlapping with the steady pattern of rain.

Maybe, for just a moment, he could stop thinking.

He spotted a bench nearby, mostly dry under the awning of a closed shop. With one last glance around, he made his way over and sat down, stretching his leg out slightly. His knee twinged in protest, but he ignored it, leaning his head back against the wall.

For now, he'd just sit. Just for a little while.

Mydei sat there for longer than he intended, rain tapping against the awning above him, cold settling deep into his limbs. His phone rested in his palm, his thumb hovering over the screen. He could start looking for another hotel—see if something had opened up, try his luck again—but the thought alone exhausted him. His knee was stiff, the soreness settling in stubbornly, and if he was being honest with himself, the idea of wandering the city any longer was out of the question.

His gaze flicked to his call log.

You should’ve let me know when you were coming. I would’ve made time for you.

Mydei exhaled sharply through his nose.

This was stupid. He could find another place. He didn’t need to rely on Phainon. He didn’t need to take the easy way out, even if every logical part of him knew this wasn’t about pride—it was just practicality.

His knee hurt. His body was cold.

He muttered a curse under his breath and pulled up the conversation.

Is your offer still open?

The response was almost immediate.

ฅ^•ﻌ•^ฅ Always. Where are you? I’ll send a car.

Mydei stared at the message, fingers tightening around his phone. Phainon hadn’t even teased him for it. Hadn’t rubbed it in or made a joke at his expense.

That should’ve made this easier. Instead, it made his chest feel too tight.

With a short sigh, he sent his location and pocketed his phone, tilting his head back to stare at the blurred lights of the city.

This was going to be a long night.

A few minutes passed before a sleek car pulled up beside him, the sound of the engine humming in the rain-soaked quiet. Mydei stood up slowly, his leg protesting the movement. The wet pavement made each step feel more awkward than it had to, but he pushed through, ignoring the pang that shot up his knee with every weight shift. He didn’t want to think about it anymore—just one more thing to add to the list of inconveniences tonight.

He reached the car, tapping on the window. The driver rolled it down, giving him a small nod.

“You Mydei?” the man asked, glancing at him through the rain-dappled glass.

“Yeah,” Mydei replied, pulling the collar of his jacket higher to shield his neck from the cold. He swung open the door and slid into the back seat, trying to avoid putting too much pressure on his leg as he shifted.

The car sped through the streets of New York, the city lights flashing by in a blur. Mydei stared out the window, watching the rain streak down the glass. His thoughts wandered back to the conversation with Phainon—how it had felt strangely normal, despite the distance between them. Despite everything.

He couldn’t remember the last time they had talked like that, casually. The distance, the years of silence, and his stubbornness—it all felt like a distant memory now. He was here, after all. In the same city.

The driver took a turn, and soon enough, the car came to a stop in front of a large building. Mydei rubbed his face, his fingers brushing over the stubble growing on his jaw, and sighed. This was it.

He stepped out and gave the driver a small nod before heading toward the entrance. The lobby was quiet, the lights soft and calming compared to the bustle of the city outside. It felt a little surreal like he didn’t belong in such a place.

The receptionist at the desk smiled warmly when she saw him. “Good evening, sir. Your suite is ready.”

He nodded silently, still processing the whole situation. This wasn’t just a suite. It was Phainon’s suite. Phainon had offered it without a second thought.

After a quick exchange, Mydei grabbed the room key and headed for the elevator. His legs were starting to feel heavy, and the ache in his knee wasn’t letting up. The lift doors closed, and he leaned against the wall as it ascended, staring at his reflection in the mirrored walls, trying to ignore the weight of his thoughts.

When the doors opened, he stepped out into the hallway and made his way to the door Phainon had said would be his. The key turned in the lock with a soft click, and he stepped inside. The suite was quiet, spacious, and almost too nice for someone who was still trying to get used to being there.

Mydei dropped his bag by the door, his body slumping with relief as he let himself relax for the first time that day. He glanced around, taking in the lavish decor, but his mind was too preoccupied to appreciate the space fully.

Phainon had offered this. No strings attached.

Maybe he didn’t have to make everything so complicated. Maybe, for once, he could just breathe.

But when he heard the sound of rain hitting the windows, he felt the tightness in his chest again.

It wasn’t about the offer.

It was about what he might be feeling again.

And that was something he wasn’t sure he was ready to face.

Moving On, Not So Much

Chapter Notes

> Holy shit, my fingers, my poor fingers. I need me a Americone Dream ice cream and an Ice Golden Eagle pronto, call me basic idgaf
>
> Jkjk, finally finished the editing for this, enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The moment Mydei stepped into the suite, the weight of the day seemed to settle deeper in his bones. The world outside blurred, the sounds of New York just barely registering in the back of his mind as he moved through the expansive space. He felt disconnected like he was walking through someone else's life—too caught up in his thoughts to take in the luxury of his surroundings.

His hand was on the arm of the chair, ready to drop his bag when—

The bathroom door creaked open.

Mydei froze.

Out of nowhere, Phainon emerged from the bathroom, a towel hanging loosely around his waist, his wet hair dripping dark strands down his neck. For a split second, their eyes met, and Mydei's heart stuttered. His brain malfunctioned. The sudden sight—Phainon, looking all too effortless, just as gorgeous as he always was but in a completely different way now—sent a jolt through him that he wasn't prepared for.

Phainon blinked, clearly surprised to see him standing there before his lips curved into a teasing grin.

"You're here already? Great!" he said casually, as though he hadn't just walked out of the shower in nothing but a towel.

Mydei's body seized up. His mind scrambled for words, but everything just turned into static. He could feel his face burning, blood rushing to his ears. *What do I do? What the hell do I do?*

Before he could even think, his hand jerked forward—slamming the door shut with a thud.

"Put some damn clothes on!" Mydei barked, his voice shaky, his heart hammering in his chest. He didn't care how loud he sounded. He was *dying* in embarrassment.

Inside the suite, he stood there for a moment, staring at the door like it was the only thing that could save him from the wave of awkwardness crashing over him. His knee thumped painfully, but he barely noticed the discomfort. Everything else—every ounce of his focus—was consumed by the sheer mortification of the situation. His breath came a little too fast, but he tried to calm himself down, swallowing the lump in his throat.

For a long moment, all he could hear was the sound of his own racing heart.

Then, through the door, Phainon's laughter echoed, light and carefree. "You're kidding, right?" His voice was muffled but unmistakably amused. "I'm just trying to make you feel at home. Can't help that I'm the only one here with decent looks, right?"

Mydei scrubbed a hand over his face. *This is going so well*, he thought bitterly. *I am the worst.*

He stood frozen for another moment, trying to catch his breath, but the sounds from behind the door didn't stop. Phainon's voice drifted through again, more playful than before, "Just chill out, Mydei. I'll be done in a second."

Mydei stared at the door, trying to force his body to move, to escape the awkwardness. It felt like his insides were on fire.

Finally, after what felt like an eternity, the door clicked open again. Phainon stepped into the room, now dressed—casual, loose t-shirt and shorts—his

hair still damp, though now more presentable. He leaned casually against the doorframe, looking completely unbothered by the whole situation. His grin was even bigger now, clearly enjoying Mydei's discomfort.

"Better?" Phainon asked his tone teasing but not unkind.

Mydei looked at him, fighting the urge to roll his eyes. "Yeah, sure. Whatever," he muttered, his voice betraying how flustered he still felt. He quickly glanced away, his gaze catching the corner of the room, anywhere but on Phainon, who was enjoying himself too much.

Phainon just chuckled, stepping fully into the room. "Good. I was about to offer you a drink, but now you're just making me feel awkward. Make yourself comfortable. I've got the place to myself, so we can just relax."

Relax. Mydei almost laughed at the idea of relaxing, but not after that. He still felt like he was trying to recover from the moment he'd walked in here. But there was something in Phainon's easygoing tone—his usual charm—that made Mydei just nod if only to move past it.

"Right," he muttered. "Guess I'll just… sit down then."

Phainon waved a hand dismissively, heading toward the fridge. "Yeah, go ahead. I'll get you something to drink. You've probably traveled a long way. It's on me."

Mydei, still trying to get his bearings, sank into the couch, trying to ignore the strange tension in the air. He tried to focus on anything other than how much his heart was still pounding.

It wasn't just the sudden vulnerability—seeing Phainon so casually undressed had shaken him more than he realized. It was something deeper, something unspoken between them. And Mydei wasn't sure he was ready to face it just yet.

The room fell into a silence that felt thick with unacknowledged awkwardness, and Mydei focused on the flickering lights outside, the hum of the city barely filtering through the windows.

Finally, Phainon returned, drink in hand, and handed it over with a grin. “Did you miss New York at all?” he asked, trying to fill the space with something casual. “I mean, I can’t blame you if you didn’t. It’s a bit much.”

Mydei took a drink, his fingers brushing Phainon’s for the briefest second. He blinked, catching his breath. “It’s fine,” he muttered, eyes still flicking around the room. “Still trying to get used to it.”

Phainon didn’t press him, thankfully. Instead, he leaned against the counter, waiting for Mydei to say more—but Mydei didn’t know what else to say. The air felt too heavy now, full of things neither of them could put into words.

For now, Mydei focused on the drink in his hand, trying not to think about the wave of confusion and embarrassment still crashing over him.

Because, for the first time in a while, things between him and Phainon felt a little too real.

The night stretched on in an easy flow of conversation. After the initial awkwardness of the bathroom incident, Phainon and Mydei settled into a more familiar rhythm. The tension had softened, replaced by the kind of casual camaraderie that came with years of friendship—or whatever this was between them now.

They talked about everything and nothing. Phainon teased Mydei about his unwillingness to embrace the chaos of New York, and Mydei rolled his eyes, but there was a comfort in their back-and-forth that settled some of the unease still lingering in Mydei’s chest.

At some point, Phainon pulled up an old movie on the TV, one of those cheesy action flicks that had been a favorite of theirs back when they were younger before everything had become complicated. Mydei barely paid attention to the plot—he didn’t care—but the familiar banter, the explosions, and ridiculous fight scenes felt grounding. It was like they were teenagers again, sitting on a couch, laughing at bad dialogue, and eating junk food.

And maybe that’s what made the night feel easy. Phainon wasn’t forcing anything. He was just here, laughing with Mydei, his usual cocky charm mixing effortlessly with the more relaxed, quieter moments they were sharing.

At some point, Phainon moved to stretch out on the couch, but before he could make himself comfortable, his head flopped over onto Mydei’s shoulder with a soft, hal-asleep chuckle. Mydei didn’t react right away, his mind too slow to register what had just happened. Phainon was warm, his hair still damp and soft against Mydei’s skin. The weight of his head felt both natural and unexpected.

“You’re not that tired, are you?” Mydei teased, his voice a little too quiet, not entirely sure how to react to the sudden proximity. Phainon didn’t reply, but his breathing had already slowed, and he seemed more comfortable than Mydei had seen him in a while.

Mydei shifted slightly, trying not to disturb Phainon, but the sensation of his head resting on him felt oddly intimate, different from their usual banter-filled closeness. There was no teasing, no pretending. Just two people in a room, quietly existing together. Mydei felt his breath even out as the strange knot in his chest loosened.

It wasn’t like he hadn’t spent time with Phainon before—hadn’t shared private moments, even, but this felt different. For the first time in a while, it felt like they were both just… there. No rivalry. No complicated feelings. Just two people, sharing a night without expectations.

Mydei leaned back into the couch, his thoughts swirling, but he didn’t move. He wasn’t sure if he should. He didn’t know how long it would last, this quiet moment where the distance between them was just that—silent, comfortable distance.

But as Phainon continued to sleep, his breathing steady and soft against Mydei’s shoulder, Mydei found himself for once just letting go of the thoughts running through his head. The constant ache in his knee was still there, but in this moment, it almost didn’t matter. He had spent so long keeping his walls up, protecting himself from whatever this thing was

between them. But with Phainon's head on his shoulder, the walls felt a little less necessary.

He didn't know how much time passed, but eventually, he felt his eyelids grow heavy, the quiet hum of the city outside lulling him into a drowsy state. For once, Mydei let himself relax, just a little, feeling the warmth of Phainon next to him. It wasn't the resolution of everything, but it was enough for now.

Eventually, Phainon stirred a little, shifting slightly, but didn't fully wake. Mydei felt his chest tighten slightly at the thought of Phainon leaving, but for now, he just stayed there, waiting for the next moment, whatever it might bring.

Maybe they didn't need to talk about all the things that had happened. Maybe tonight could just be… tonight.

And that, strangely enough, was enough. *(He keeps telling himself it's enough, it has to be.)*

The morning light filtered softly through the windows, the quiet hum of the city outside barely breaking the stillness in the room. Mydei was the first to wake, his eyes slowly flicking open, the warmth of Phainon's presence still pressing against him. For a few moments, he just lay there, the early morning light brushing against Phainon's damp hair, the way it fell in gentle waves around his face. His expression was relaxed, free from the usual tension Mydei saw when Phainon was awake.

It felt strange, at this moment. Mydei had spent years not allowing himself to acknowledge how much he watched Phainon—how much he took in every small detail, every glance, every shift in his posture. But now, with Phainon peacefully asleep beside him, he let himself indulge in it just for a second. The way Phainon's chest rose and fell in steady rhythm, the soft curve of his lips, the way his brow furrowed slightly even in sleep.

Mydei wasn't sure how long he lingered like that, but he eventually let out a quiet sigh and shifted, feeling a slight twinge in his knee that reminded him it was still there, still a part of him. His movement caused Phainon to stir

just a little, and for a split second, Mydei thought he might have woken up fully, but Phainon just shifted closer, his head still resting against Mydei's shoulder.

A small smile tugged at the corner of Mydei's lips. It was fleeting, but it was there. He didn't get moments like this often. And in the quiet of the morning, with Phainon so unguarded, Mydei allowed himself to feel it for a moment.

But the peace couldn't last forever. Eventually, Phainon stirred again, his eyes blinking open, the usual mischievous glint already returning to his gaze as he realized he was still leaning against Mydei.

"Well, good morning," Phainon said, his voice still a little groggy but warm, the teasing tone creeping in immediately. "Did you enjoy the view, or were you just admiring my stunning good looks?"

Mydei's smile faded quickly as he shifted away, rolling his eyes and pulling himself up to sit, his tone returning to its usual gruffness. "Get up, you idiot. Practice's calling."

Phainon stretched and yawned, the sudden shift back to his usual self making Mydei's chest tighten just a little. He missed this—the familiar banter, the way Phainon was always so effortlessly confident. It felt almost like the night before had been a dream.

"You're such a killjoy," Phainon muttered with a grin, running a hand through his hair. "I was enjoying the quiet, but fine, I'll go be a responsible adult."

Mydei smirked, watching as Phainon stretched his legs. "That's what happens when you get a good night's sleep," he replied, trying to keep the banter light, though he still felt a bit of unease creeping in.

Phainon raised an eyebrow, clearly noticing the shift in Mydei's mood. "You sure you don't want to come watch me practice later?" he asked, his tone teasing but sincere. "I could use a friendly face. You know, since you're in town."

Mydei hesitated, the offer unexpected. “I don’t know. I’m still adjusting to this place… and my leg’s still giving me hell,” he admitted, his voice quieter than usual.

Phainon gave him a knowing look, but there was no judgment in it, only understanding. “You could just sit and watch. You know, for old time’s sake.”

Mydei’s eyes flicked to Phainon, and for a moment, he was quiet. The thought of sitting on the sidelines and watching Phainon play didn’t sound all that terrible. Soccer had always been his thing, even if he couldn’t run anymore.

“Alright,” Mydei said finally, surprising even himself. “I’ll come watch. But don’t expect me to cheer you on or anything.”

Phainon chuckled. “Wouldn’t dream of it. Just show up. I’ll make sure you don’t fall asleep again,” he teased with a wink before grabbing his bag.

Mydei stood up, wincing slightly as he shifted his weight on his injured leg, but he quickly brushed it off. It was strange, he realized, how much he’d missed being around Phainon—how comfortable it felt, even after everything that had changed.

“Alright, let’s get this over with,” Mydei muttered under his breath as he followed Phainon out of the hotel, trying to ignore the flicker of excitement in his chest.

As they walked toward the practice field, the weight of the day ahead settled around them, but there was a strange sense of calm between them too. Maybe it was just the familiarity of the old rhythm between them. Maybe it was just the way Phainon’s presence always seemed to make everything else fade into the background.

For now, Mydei was content to follow, even if only as a spectator.

The practice was in full swing by the time Mydei had found his spot on the bleachers. The sound of cleats against the turf and the sharp whistle of the

coach filled the air, and Mydei couldn’t help but smile as he watched Phainon glide across the field. The familiar rhythm of the game was both soothing and painful to him. It was something he loved, something he missed, and yet every movement, every sprint Phainon made, only reminded him of what he’d lost.

He’d been here for a while, and while part of him hated just sitting on the sidelines, watching, it was still something—something to see Phainon back in his element, the joy and the ease with which he moved. The way his teammates passed him the ball as though they knew exactly where he was going to be, and how he effortlessly maneuvered around challenges.

It was impossible to ignore the nagging feeling in Mydei’s chest. There was a gnawing sense of envy, a deep ache that reminded him of how much he’d once been a part of this, how seamlessly he and Phainon had worked together. He could almost hear the old banter they used to share during practice, the light teasing, the easy camaraderie. But now…

Now, it was just Phainon. And Mydei.

On the sidelines.

He tried to ignore the knot in his stomach as Phainon scored yet another brilliant goal, eliciting a cheer from the rest of the team. Mydei couldn’t help but clap, his face breaking into a proud smile, even as he fought off the feeling that he was too far removed from it all.

As the practice wore on, the younger players started to fidget, their attention drifting away from the drills and toward each other. A group of them huddled in a circle, laughing and gesturing to Mydei, who was still sitting on the bleachers, trying to make himself as invisible as possible.

“Hey!” one of the players called out, his voice brimming with excitement. “Come join us! Let’s play a quick practice match, just for fun!”

Mydei froze, suddenly feeling the weight of all their gazes on him. The thought of getting up, of trying to participate, made his stomach turn. He

knew his knee wouldn’t hold up—not in a real match, not with all those younger, faster players running circles around him.

He shook his head, trying to smile through the discomfort. “No, I’m good,” he muttered, brushing the hair from his eyes, hoping they wouldn’t push it. But they didn’t seem to take the hint, their enthusiasm only growing.

“Come on, you used to play, right?” one of them said, leaning forward with a grin. “You can’t be that out of practice.”

Mydei felt his face heat up. It wasn’t that he didn’t want to play, it was that he physically couldn’t. The thought of explaining his injury to a group of strangers, let alone in front of Phainon, felt too humiliating. It wasn’t just his knee that had been hurt; it was his pride, too.

Before he could figure out how to decline again, Phainon’s voice rang out from across the field.

“Enough slacking off!” Phainon called, his voice commanding enough to cut through the chatter. “Get back to work, all of you. We don’t have time for side games. Let’s finish strong.”

The younger players groaned in protest, but they quickly complied, scattering back to their positions. Mydei sighed in relief, feeling a weight lift off his shoulders. It wasn’t that he wanted to hide forever; it was just… easier this way.

He caught Phainon’s eye as the older man jogged over to the sidelines, a quick nod acknowledging him before Phainon started talking to the coach. For a moment, Mydei felt like they were still connected—like they could share a look, a small gesture, and it would all feel just like before. But the moment passed, and Phainon was back to being the center of the team, barking orders and organizing plays.

Mydei sank further into the bench, crossing his arms and watching the game from the distance. His thoughts swirled, the familiar pang of longing returning as he saw Phainon back in his element, doing what he loved. It

was bittersweet, watching him so effortlessly shine while Mydei remained stuck on the sidelines.

The rest of the practice went by in a blur. Mydei stayed quiet, his mind working through the frustrations he never let anyone see. He'd gotten used to the feeling of being invisible, but that didn't make it any easier.

As the final whistle blew, signaling the end of practice, Mydei stood slowly, stretching his legs, aware of the stiffness setting in. Phainon was already heading toward the locker room, his teammates following closely behind, their voices buzzing with excitement.

"Hey," Phainon called over his shoulder, catching Mydei's eye. "You sticking around? I'm grabbing something to eat. You're welcome to join."

Mydei hesitated, then gave a small nod. "Yeah, I'll catch up. Just need a minute."

Phainon smiled, a knowing look in his eyes before he disappeared into the locker room. Mydei watched him go, feeling that familiar tug in his chest. Maybe it was easier to stay quiet, to stay out of the way. But part of him still wanted to try—wanted to be there with Phainon, even if it was just for a meal.

The small, quiet restaurant Phainon chose wasn't too far from the training facility. It had a relaxed atmosphere, dim lighting, and simple, hearty food—nothing fancy. It wasn't the kind of place where the media would follow or where Phainon's fame would shine too brightly. It was a comfort zone for both of them.

Phainon ordered first, his usual laid-back attitude as he chatted with the waitress. When it was Mydei's turn, he wasn't sure what to say. A glance at the menu was all he needed to know what he wanted, but something in him hesitated, something that made this simple decision feel more complicated than it should have.

Phainon looked over at him, a small grin on his face. "You're not gonna get the same thing as me, are you? You better not be stealing my order."

Mydei blinked, half-surprised by the teasing tone. “I’m not a copycat,” he replied, his voice a little gruffer than he intended. But there was something comforting about it—about the way Phainon could still make him feel like they were just two old friends.

Phainon smirked, leaning back in his chair. “Good. Because if you did, I’d have to question your taste in food. And I don’t know if I’d be able to respect you anymore.”

The banter felt like the simplest thing, yet it made Mydei’s chest tighten in a way that had nothing to do with his knee. There was an easy comfort in being with Phainon like this, even if it still felt like the ground beneath him might give way.

Dinner was light. They talked about everything and nothing, from random anecdotes about their time on the field to Phainon’s latest challenge with his team. At one point, the conversation turned to old memories—years ago, back when everything felt simpler. Phainon laughed when Mydei mentioned how ridiculous the old team dinners had been, joking about some embarrassing incident from when they were younger.

“I swear, you and Phagousa were the biggest troublemakers,” Mydei remarked, trying not to let his voice reveal too much as he took a bite of his food. The memories weren’t always easy to revisit.

Phainon’s grin softened. “Maybe, but you were always the one looking out for us. You kept us in check when we needed it.”

“Someone had to.” Mydei’s voice was quieter, and for a moment, he wasn’t sure what to do with the nostalgia, the bittersweet taste of it all.

Phainon didn’t press, thankfully. Instead, he leaned back in his chair, tapping his fingers lightly on the table. “I never thanked you for that, you know.”

Mydei didn’t know how to respond. The words were simple enough, but they carried weight. He met Phainon’s gaze for a moment, trying to gauge if there was more to it—if Phainon meant it in a way that wasn’t just casual.

But before he could say anything, Phainon's expression shifted, lightening up again. "Alright, enough of the sentimental stuff. I can't handle it. You're making me feel like we're at some kind of therapy session." He laughed, and the sound was warm.

Mydei couldn't help but smile a little, even if it was in his usual reserved way. "You're the one who brought it up."

Phainon just shrugged, still smiling, and then looked down at his empty plate. "Guess I'm just a sucker for nostalgia. What about you, though? Have you ever thought about getting back into the game?"

The question hit him in a way he wasn't expecting. Mydei looked up, meeting Phainon's eyes. It wasn't a loaded question, but the weight of it felt heavier than any other.

"I do," Mydei said, his voice barely above a murmur. "But it's not the same."

Phainon raised an eyebrow, his expression softening. "I get that. It's tough to let go, huh?"

Mydei nodded slowly, the words he wanted to say stuck in his throat. He didn't want to make it more than it was. Didn't want to admit how much it hurt. "Yeah. It's different now."

There was a brief silence between them, the noise of the restaurant fading in the background as Phainon seemed to take the moment in. Then, with a soft laugh, he shifted in his chair, clearly trying to break the tension. "Well, as long as you're around to help me with my rehab, I guess I can't complain."

Mydei rolled his eyes but couldn't help the small smile that tugged at his lips. "Yeah, I'm real good at that," he said, his voice dry, trying to shrug off the feeling of things shifting between them.

But as they finished their meal, there was this new understanding between them. Mydei wasn't sure what it meant yet, but for the first time in a long

while, he allowed himself to relax a little, even if it was just for this one night.

After their quiet dinner, Phainon and Mydei returned to the hotel, the soft hum of the evening settling over them. They didn't talk much on the way back, the weight of the day lingering in the air. Mydei couldn't shake the feeling of being on the outside, watching everything Phainon had worked so hard for. He wanted to be part of it, wanted to be with him, but it felt like every step forward was one away from the life he once knew. The injury still haunted him, sometimes in ways he couldn't express.

But for tonight, he just let himself be in Phainon's company. The familiarity of it, the easy silence, was a comfort he hadn't realized he craved so much. Phainon, as always, seemed unfazed by the world around him. He was used to the attention, used to the pressure. Maybe that's why he could be so calm, so at ease. Mydei envied that calmness, even if he'd never admit it out loud.

They settled into their respective spaces in the hotel room, each doing their own thing. Phainon stretched out on the couch, flicking through channels with disinterest, while Mydei sat by the window, his mind elsewhere. The quiet moments between them didn't feel uncomfortable, just a bit heavy, as though the unspoken things were finally catching up to them.

Eventually, Phainon gave a stretch and glanced at Mydei. "Long day, huh?"

Mydei grunted in acknowledgment. "Yeah."

Phainon's voice softened slightly like he was testing the waters. "You okay?"

For a moment, Mydei was silent. It wasn't an easy question. What was he supposed to say? *Yeah, I'm just fine watching you live the life I used to have, while I'm stuck here in this hotel room nursing an old injury that has taken everything from me.* But he didn't say any of that. Instead, he just nodded. "I'm good."

Phainon studied him for a moment, the familiar teasing glint in his eyes slowly fading into something more contemplative. But, as usual, he didn't

press further. “Well, I’m gonna hit the bed soon. Big game tomorrow.”

“Yeah, good luck,” Mydei replied, his voice a little quieter than he intended.

Phainon grinned, stretching his arms. “Thanks. You should get some rest too. We’ll need you cheering us on.”

Mydei only nodded again, glancing at his phone. The quiet between them felt natural now, and before long, they both retired to their beds for the night. Mydei closed his eyes, trying to quiet the thoughts swirling in his head, but sleep came slow.

The stadium was alive with energy, the crowd’s roar echoing in Mydei’s chest as he sat on the sidelines, bundled in a jacket that did little to protect him from the cold air. His knee, though better than it had been, still pulsed quietly beneath the layers of fabric. He adjusted his position, but no matter how many times he shifted, it didn’t quite settle. Watching the game always stirred something deep inside him—part admiration, part longing—but today it was more than that. It was a reminder. A reminder that he was no longer part of this world, not in the way he wanted to be.

Phainon was at the center of it all, of course. His movements were fluid and precise, a stark contrast to Mydei’s limitations. It was like watching a dancer at the peak of their craft, every motion perfectly timed. Phainon weaved through defenders, his footwork so sharp it almost seemed like he could predict the next move before anyone else on the field even had the chance to react.

Mydei found it hard not to stare, but not for the reasons he’d like to admit. It wasn’t just the skill—though that was undeniable—it was the way Phainon carried himself, like he was always one step ahead, never faltering, always playing with a kind of effortless confidence. He seemed almost untouchable.

Every time Phainon moved, it felt as if the whole game bent around him. The ball practically glued to his foot, he made it look easy, breezing past opponents with the grace of someone who had honed their craft for years.

Phainon was a star, not just because of his skill but because of the way he made it look as if this was what he was born to do.

Mydei shifted in his seat, feeling the familiar weight of envy stirring inside him. It wasn't just Phainon's skill that hurt—it was the reminder that he had once been part of it all. He had been there, on the field, racing toward goals and making plays that would keep the crowd on their feet.

But that was before.

The pain in his knee flared for a brief moment, reminding him why he wasn't out there anymore. Why he couldn't run, couldn't jump. Why he had to watch from the sidelines, like a spectator in the world he once belonged to?

As the game progressed, Phainon's team gained the upper hand, and Mydei couldn't help but feel a surge of pride. His hands clapped rhythmically against his thighs as Phainon's team pushed forward, dominating the field. He wasn't part of the action, but his heart raced with the same intensity, a mix of pride and bittersweet loss.

Phainon, with his sharp eyes and infectious smile, scored a goal that secured the win. The crowd erupted, chanting his name. Mydei couldn't help but join in, his voice part of the chorus that praised Phainon's skill.

Phainon's teammates swarmed him, lifting him on their shoulders, and for a moment, everything felt like it was in the right place. He was the star. He was the one who had earned this victory, and Mydei couldn't help but feel that pang of longing— that *could've* been me . That *should have* been me.

But that's not the reality anymore.

Phainon's triumphant grin, and his wide eyes as he waved to the crowd, made it clear that he was in his element. He was thriving, a god on the field, untouchable. Mydei couldn't help but notice how effortlessly *fine* Phainon looked—he wasn't just playing; he was living it. And it stung, more than it should.

Mydei stood to join the crowd's applause, though it felt almost robotic. The pride was there, sure, but it was mixed with something else. A quiet ache. A sharp, gnawing sense that he would never again feel that rush of adrenaline, never again experience the joy of that victory in the same way.

After the game, the frenzy of reporters surrounded Phainon, their microphones, and cameras flashing as they all clamored to get a piece of the action. Mydei stayed to the side, fading into the background, trying to remain invisible in the sea of people.

He watched from the sidelines, leaning against a barrier, his arms crossed tightly across his chest. Phainon handled the media with ease, his usual charming smile and easy answers rolling off his tongue.

"Phainon, incredible game today! You were on fire," one reporter said, her voice laced with excitement. "We've been hearing a lot of buzz about next season—do you have anything to share about what's coming up?"

Phainon smiled, shrugging in his characteristic nonchalance. "Right now, I'm just focused on enjoying the moment. The future can wait."

There was a flicker of something in his eyes, something like quiet satisfaction, and the reporters ate it up. But then, a new voice cut through the chatter, an older man who had covered sports for years.

"Phainon, you and Mydei were an unstoppable pair. You both brought something special to the team. With his injury, we all wonder what could have been. What are your thoughts on that?"

The question hit Mydei like a punch to the gut, even though he hadn't expected it. He looked away quickly, swallowing hard. He wasn't even sure if Phainon knew he was here, but the mention of his injury, the way it was brought up so casually— *what could have been* —was enough to rattle him.

The reporters' voices faded into a dull buzz in the background as he tried to hold himself together. Mydei couldn't stop the rush of thoughts that flooded his mind, the shame and the guilt that had been quietly lingering for years.

He was still broken. He would always be broken.

The reporter kept going, speaking in a tone that was almost too gentle. “Such a shame what happened to Mydei, don’t you think, Phainon? It’s a real loss.”

Phainon didn’t immediately respond. His eyes flickered toward Mydei for just a split second, catching him standing at the edge of the group before he turned back to the reporters. “It’s never easy when a teammate has to go,” Phainon said, his voice steady but measured, “but that’s life. You move on.”

The silence that followed felt like a crack in the atmosphere. Mydei could feel the sting of those words more than he wanted to admit, but he bit his lip and pushed it all down. He was fine. *He was fine.*

He didn’t know how long he stood there in the aftermath of Phainon’s response. His mind was already racing, bitter thoughts flashing through his head. *That’s life. You move on.* As if it was that simple. As if he —someone who had shared years of sweat, blood, and victories with Phainon—was so easily discarded. Mydei knew he was being unreasonable. He knew it wasn’t fair to expect Phainon to have some grand emotional reaction. But it hurt more than he wanted to admit.

The press event moved forward, everyone speaking in generalities about the game, the matchups, and the upcoming season. Mydei tried to focus, tried to pretend that the words didn’t keep replaying in his head, but he couldn’t help it. The sting of Phainon’s words was like a bruise that wouldn’t fade.

After the press conference wrapped up, the team dispersed in their usual chaotic manner. Phainon was surrounded by teammates, chatting, and laughing, their smiles easy and natural. But Mydei—always on the outside —felt more alone than ever. He didn’t want to be here. He didn’t want to see Phainon look so effortlessly fine, so unaffected by everything. The way the reporters had latched onto his success, the way Phainon made it all look easy—every smile, every joke, every effortless word made Mydei feel small.

And yet, he couldn’t look away.

By the time the team headed back to the hotel, Mydei could feel the weight of his emotions pressing down on him. The hotel lobby was bustling with players and staff, but Mydei felt isolated. He hadn't spoken to Phainon since the press event, and he didn't know how to handle the distance between them. Everything had shifted in those few moments—the silence, the look Phainon gave him, the way Phainon had so easily brushed off the past.

It wasn't supposed to be like this.

Phainon had been his teammate. His *friend* . They had been everything to each other. But now… now Phainon was just another player. And Mydei? Mydei was a has-been. A broken relic. He hated how his thoughts spiraled, how the bitterness felt like a vine twisting tighter around his chest.

Before he realized it, he was standing in the hallway outside his room, the door already cracked open. He leaned against the wall, trying to steady his breath, but the thoughts kept coming. The resentment. The jealousy. The *hurt* seemed to bleed into every corner of his mind.

He could hear footsteps approaching, slow and deliberate, and he turned to see Phainon standing there. Phainon's face was unreadable, his hands tucked into the pockets of his jacket. For a moment, neither of them said anything. It was too quiet. Too much.

"What's going on?" Phainon finally asked, his tone quieter now, almost hesitant.

Mydei's heart raced. He knew what he wanted to say, but it felt like a wall was blocking his throat. He opened his mouth but the words wouldn't come. So, instead, he forced a laugh—a bitter, hollow sound.

"Nothing," he said, but even to his ears, the word felt like a lie. "Just… just trying to keep it together, you know? The usual."

Phainon didn't buy it. His brow furrowed, and he stepped a little closer. "You're lying. Something's wrong, Mydei. I can see it."

That was when Mydei's anger flared. The tightness in his chest, the gnawing frustration—everything spilled out in an unguarded rush.

"I just… I just can't do this anymore, Phainon," Mydei snapped, the words sharp and biting. He ran a hand through his hair, shaking his head in disbelief at himself. "I can't keep pretending like I'm fine with everything. Like I'm fine with watching you win, watching you live this *perfect* life while I'm stuck here, a fucking cripple—"

"Hey, hey—" Phainon stepped forward, clearly trying to calm him down, but Mydei took a step back, shaking his head more forcefully now. He couldn't stop. It was like everything inside him had broken free, and he couldn't contain it anymore.

"I never wanted to be this guy," Mydei spat. "I never wanted to be the guy who's just fine with being left behind, with being forgotten. But here I am. And you? You don't even care. You've got Cyrene. You've got the team. You've got *everything* , Phainon. And I'm just the guy who—"

He cut himself off, his words hanging in the air, all the shame and resentment catching in his throat. The vulnerability that he hadn't meant to show was suddenly there, raw and exposed.

Phainon was silent for a long moment. His expression was unreadable, like he didn't know how to respond, or maybe didn't want to. But then, the words Mydei had been holding back finally spilled out.

"I miss you," Mydei said, the confession quiet, almost reluctant. "I miss what we had. I miss us, Phainon. I miss being someone you could look at, someone who mattered to you. I know I'm not that anymore, but it fucking hurts." His chest tightened, like a weight pressing down on him. "I don't know when it all changed. But now… now I'm just here, stuck in the past, watching you move on without me."

The moment the words left his mouth, Mydei felt like he couldn't breathe. He had said too much. He had been exposed too much. And now, there was no taking it back.

Phainon stared at him, his lips pressed into a thin line. He didn't say anything for a long time, and Mydei felt his stomach twist in knots. The silence stretched out, each second heavier than the last.

"I didn't mean—" Mydei started, but Phainon held up a hand, cutting him off.

"I don't…" Phainon started, his voice quiet, hesitant, "I don't know what to say, Mydei. I don't want to hurt you. I never wanted that. But…" He trailed off, his eyes searching Mydei's face as though looking for something he couldn't find.

Mydei wanted to look away, wanted to disappear, but he couldn't. The confession was out there now, and Phainon's silence hurt more than any words could. Finally, Phainon spoke again, his voice low and distant.

"I think you need some time, Mydei," Phainon said, the words like ice. "I think we both do."

The weight of his words hit Mydei like a slap. He nodded, stiffly, but the tightness in his chest didn't ease. Phainon's voice, Phainon's eyes—they were nothing like what he'd hoped for. Nothing like what he needed.

"I'll be… I'll be in my room," Phainon said, turning away.

Mydei stood there for a moment, frozen, feeling every bit of the distance between them.

Then, without another word, Phainon walked away.

Phainon's heart pounded in his chest as he stepped away from Mydei, the weight of the conversation still pressing down on him. He could feel the heat of the moment still burning his skin, the rawness of Mydei's words echoing in his head.

The hallway was quiet now, the noise of the bustling hotel lobby a distant hum. Phainon could hear his breathing, steady but too loud in the silence.

He had barely processed what had just happened. He hadn’t known what to say— how to say it—when Mydei’s confession had slipped out. That vulnerability, that unfiltered pain, it had knocked the air out of him.

I miss you.

Phainon had always known Mydei was struggling, but hearing those words from him? It was like a slap to the face. He hadn’t expected it.

The truth was, Phainon hadn’t known what to feel for a long time. There were too many layers to everything that had happened between them. Mydei’s injury, the way their worlds had split in two. The team’s success, and the ever-growing distance between them. But now? Now there was this weight in his chest, and Phainon couldn’t tell if it was guilt or something more complicated.

He hadn’t wanted to hurt Mydei. Hell, he never wanted that. But when it came down to it, Phainon had never been good at dealing with feelings that weren’t straightforward. He hadn’t been able to face the complexity of it all. He didn’t know what he was supposed to say. Didn’t know how to handle the ache in his chest when he saw Mydei standing there, raw and vulnerable, revealing things Phainon had never asked him to.

The thing was, he had always cared about Mydei. More than he cared to admit, even to himself. But the lines between friendship and something more had blurred long before Mydei’s injury, and Phainon didn’t know how to pull them back into place. What if the things he felt for Mydei weren’t supposed to be romantic? What if everything had shifted in ways he couldn’t control, in ways he didn’t want to confront?

He leaned against the cold wall of the hallway, staring at the floor, his mind racing. *You need to be there for him* , he thought. But how? How could he help Mydei when he couldn’t even sort out his feelings?

The confession had rattled him more than he expected. And Mydei, looking so broken, so exposed, had been the one to break the silence between them. The silence he’d been maintaining for months. Phainon had been avoiding

it—the tension, the unresolved emotions—and now, it had all come crashing down in that hallway.

I need to figure this out, Phainon thought, pressing his palms into his eyes. *But what do I even say to him now?*

He couldn't stay here. He couldn't stand this aching uncertainty any longer. He needed space to think, to breathe.

So, he walked away.

But even as he retreated down the hallway, his chest tightened, knowing that walking away had only made everything worse.

The buzz of the post-game excitement had begun to settle into a more familiar hum, the sound of clattering reporters and the collective excitement of the team fading as the final few team members made their way off the field. Phainon's presence seemed to linger in the air even as he moved with his usual effortless grace, like he was always a step ahead, always in motion.

Mydei stood off to the side, his bag slung over his shoulder, feeling the weight of the silence between them. It hadn't been a bad goodbye before the game—he'd managed to stay composed, keeping his thoughts in check as they exchanged casual words. But now, as he stood there, the familiar tension of their unspoken past felt heavier than ever. The words he'd accidentally spilled to Phainon, the confession that had changed everything, gnawed at him with increasing intensity.

Phainon came over with a slight smile, his usual swagger present but more subdued. "You heading out?" he asked, his voice careful but still warm.

"Yeah," Mydei answered, glancing at the ground before meeting Phainon's eyes. "Gotta catch a flight back to Texas."

Phainon nodded slowly, the smile lingering but now tinged with an awkwardness Mydei hadn't expected. "Take care of yourself, alright?"

Phainon’s words were simple, yet they carried a certain finality.

Mydei hesitated for just a moment, wondering if there was more to say. But in the end, he simply nodded. “You too. Be safe.”

Phainon seemed to hesitate as if he wanted to say more. For a split second, it almost felt like he was reaching for something deeper—something unspoken. But then, with a soft chuckle, he clapped Mydei on the back. “See you around.”

And just like that, the connection was cut. No lingering words. No promises.

As Phainon turned away to join his teammates, Mydei swallowed the lump in his throat, fighting the sudden urge to say something—anything. But what could he say? They were two people who used to share the same space, the same world, and now that world was so far apart. He’d known this moment was coming. Hadn’t he?

The days passed by, a slow burn of mundane tasks and quiet evenings spent alone. Mydei had tried to keep busy, filling his time with work, his therapy, with the things that had helped him move on from the injury. But there was always a lingering thought in the back of his mind—one that had nothing to do with soccer and everything to do with the person he hadn’t stopped thinking about since the game.

At first, the messages had been sparse but still present. Phainon would text now and then—short, simple exchanges that seemed to bounce between moments of warmth and the distance that had begun to grow between them. Mydei had tried to keep the conversation light, tried to act like everything was normal, but it was harder than he’d expected.

Days turned into weeks. The messages slowed. Phainon stopped responding with the same ease he once had. His replies were fewer and shorter. Eventually, they stopped altogether.

It wasn’t until Mydei picked up his phone one morning and saw the notification that his heart sank. There, at the top of his messages, was a

blank space where Phainon’s name had once been.

Blocked.

The realization hit Mydei like a punch to the gut, his fingers hovering over the screen as if trying to confirm that it wasn’t just a glitch. But it wasn’t. The absence felt like a slap in the face, the silence that had been building between them was now loud and undeniable.

The ache in his chest grew, heavier than he could bear. He had no idea what he’d done, but the answer seemed clear. He’d ruined it all. His confession, his vulnerability—it had driven a wedge too deep, too quickly. Maybe Phainon hadn’t been ready for it. Maybe he’d never felt the same way.

Mydei sank back onto the couch, his phone still clutched tightly in his hand. The room around him felt too quiet, too empty. He wasn’t sure what he was supposed to feel—relief, anger, regret, or just… nothing. But what he did feel was the undeniable weight of finality. That was it. There was no coming back from this.

He messed up.

It had been months since Mydei had last heard from Phainon, and despite his best efforts to move on, he couldn’t help but keep tabs on him. The match in Texas wasn’t on his radar—until it was. It was a surprise when he saw the announcement flash across his screen: Phainon’s team was playing in Texas.

He shouldn’t go. He knew he shouldn’t. His brain screamed at him to forget about it, to stay away. But the pull was too strong. Maybe it was unfinished business, maybe it was curiosity, maybe it was the lingering hope that there could be some kind of resolution. So, despite every fiber of his being telling him to turn away, Mydei found himself buying a ticket.

The day of the match, Mydei sat in the stands, feeling out of place. The roar of the crowd felt distant, like a background noise he couldn’t fully engage with. His eyes kept darting to Phainon on the field. Phainon was in his

element, smooth, focused, and effortlessly radiant on the field. The familiar ache tightened in Mydei's chest. He tried to push it down, but it wasn't easy.

The game passed in a blur, and when it was over, Phainon's team had won. Mydei lingered in the stands, watching the victory celebrations unfold. Phainon, as expected, was surrounded by his teammates, basking in the victory and the attention. But he didn't look in Mydei's direction—not once.

It hurt more than Mydei expected. But he couldn't—he wouldn't—let himself show it.

The stadium was emptying out, and the echoes of the final whistles still lingered in the air. Mydei felt the rush of people pushing past him, their voices a blur of excitement and adrenaline as they exited the stands. The last thing he wanted was to get caught in the throng, to linger in the midst of Phainon's post-match glory.

He wasn't ready for that. He wasn't ready to see him surrounded by people who didn't care about the history between them, the friendship they once had. Mydei couldn't shake the feeling that it was all slipping through his fingers—Phainon's success, his easy smiles, the ease with which he'd moved on. But Mydei couldn't. He couldn't do it anymore. He'd already stayed too long, long enough to see Phainon's victory and feel like a ghost of a life he used to have.

Turning on his heel, he made his way to the exit, ignoring the murmurs around him as people continued to talk about the game. He barely noticed the reporters' cameras as they zoomed in on the players still mingling on the field. His phone buzzed in his pocket, but he didn't look. It was probably just more messages from people he didn't have the energy to respond to.

As he approached the parking lot, the weight of it all settled on him. The lingering ache in his knee, the ache in his chest—the sharp realization that nothing would ever be the same. He didn't belong here anymore. He didn't belong in Phainon's world.

That’s when he saw the flash of movement. Phainon. His face appeared just beyond the crowd, looking like he was trying to slip away unnoticed. His gaze briefly flickered toward Mydei, and their eyes met for a fraction of a second before Phainon quickly looked away, his hand running through his hair as he pushed his way past a small cluster of reporters.

Mydei’s heart skipped a beat. Why was he avoiding everyone else but looking at him like that?

He tried to ignore the pull to go after him. He really did. He had come this far. The last thing he needed was to chase after someone who had been ignoring him for months, who had essentially locked him out of his life like some kind of unwanted relic.

But somehow, his feet moved before his brain could catch up. He couldn’t help it. He was drawn to Phainon, even now, when he should’ve been long gone.

Phainon was quick, slipping through the gaps between cars, moving like someone who knew exactly how to avoid detection. He wasn’t even trying to be sneaky, just… accustomed to the routine. He was already heading for a nearby black car, the engine running, probably already waiting for him. Mydei’s steps faltered for a moment. What was he doing?

He didn’t want to follow. He really didn’t.

But there was something about Phainon—something about seeing him so… distant, so untouchable—that pushed him forward. Every step felt like a betrayal, but he couldn’t stop himself. He found himself walking after him, his breath catching in his chest with each reluctant step.

When he reached the car, Phainon was already leaning against it, arms crossed, eyes scanning the parking lot as if he were waiting for something, or someone. He hadn’t noticed Mydei’s approach yet.

“Phainon,” Mydei called, his voice rough and uncertain.

Phainon turned, startled, his eyes locking onto Mydei's. The surprise was evident on his face, and Mydei saw the flicker of guilt, like Phainon had expected him to just leave, to disappear like he had been doing all along.

"Mydei," Phainon said, his voice unsure, like he didn't know what to say next.

It stung a little. It always did, that distance in Phainon's eyes. That barrier he'd built without even meaning to. Mydei fought the urge to look away, to let the silence stretch between them. But he was too tired for that. Too tired to keep pretending.

"You didn't think I'd show up, did you?" Mydei said, trying to keep the bite out of his words, though it was hard. Everything felt like it was about to boil over.

"I… I didn't expect this," Phainon admitted. "I thought you'd be gone by now."

"Well, I guess you don't know me as well as you thought," Mydei replied, his voice quieter now, but still laced with frustration.

Phainon sighed and ran a hand through his hair, looking away for a moment. "I never wanted to hurt you, Mydei. I never wanted to push you away. I just… I didn't know what to do, okay? I—"

"You blocked me," Mydei interrupted, his voice shaking slightly now with the weight of everything that had been left unsaid. "You blocked me, Phainon. You ignored me for months, and now you're standing here, acting like nothing happened?"

Phainon's expression shifted, guilt and confusion flashing across his face. He took a step forward, as if to close the distance, but Mydei held his ground.

"Why did you block me?" Mydei asked, the words coming out more quietly this time, like he wasn't even sure if he could bear the answer. "Why avoid me for so long?"

“I didn’t know how to fix it,” Phainon muttered, his eyes falling to the ground. “I didn’t know how to fix… us.”

The words were soft, tentative, and they cut deeper than Mydei had expected.

Before he could even respond, Phainon stepped closer again, his hands moving up to Mydei’s face, the warmth of his fingers gentle against his skin. Mydei’s breath caught in his throat, his heart pounding, his mind a tangle of questions.

“What the fuck, Phainon?” he whispered, his voice hoarse, trying to catch his breath, his mind struggling to catch up with the reality of the situation.

Phainon didn’t say anything for a beat, his chest rising and falling with rapid breaths. He looked at Mydei with something like confusion in his eyes, as if he couldn’t quite understand the weight of Mydei’s reaction. And then, with a furrowed brow, he said, “You—Cyrene? What are you talking about?”

Mydei’s heart dropped. He couldn’t believe it. The words fell from his mouth before he could stop them. “What do you mean ‘what am I talking about’? I saw you with her. I thought you and Cyrene… You’re always together, always laughing, and you make it look so easy. Like… like I was the thing you didn’t need. I felt like some kind of fucking homewrecker, Phainon, coming in and trying to get what you already had.”

The words came out harsher than he intended, a raw, bitter lump rising in his throat as the feeling of being second-best, of never being enough, clawed at him. The jealousy, the insecurity, the deep-rooted fear that Phainon would always choose someone else—that was what had torn him apart. And now, hearing Phainon so confused, it was like a slap to the face.

Phainon blinked, visibly stunned by Mydei’s words, as if they hadn’t even crossed his mind. “No,” he said quickly, taking a step back, his hands gesturing between them as if he were trying to gather his thoughts. “No, Mydei. It’s not like that. She’s just a friend, that’s all. We’ve been through a

lot, but… we're just friends, I swear to you. I never saw her like that. It was never like that."

Mydei shook his head, feeling the anger rise within him again. "Then why did you never say anything? Why didn't you explain that to me?"

Phainon's voice softened, his gaze dropping as he took a hesitant step forward. "Because I didn't know what to say. I thought… I thought you'd understand. But I fucked it up. I was stupid for not telling you."

Mydei clenched his fists at his sides, fighting back the surge of emotion threatening to break free. "You blocked me. You ignored me. I thought… I thought I was the one who was wrong. That maybe you didn't want me anymore, and you—" Mydei broke off, his voice shaking as he tried to hold it together. "You made it seem like I didn't matter."

Phainon looked up at him, his expression filled with genuine regret. He stepped forward again, closer now, until there was barely any space left between them. "I'm sorry. I was an idiot, Mydei. I was so afraid of what would happen if I really opened up. But blocking you? Ignoring you? That was the worst thing I could have done."

Mydei let out a shaky breath, his chest tightening with the weight of everything that had been left unsaid. "So you've just been—what? Pushing me away for months? All because you were too afraid to talk to me?"

"I didn't know how," Phainon confessed, his voice thick with regret. "I didn't know how to fix it, and I thought if I just… blocked you out, maybe it would hurt less. But it didn't. I can't keep pretending like I don't care. I care about you, Mydei. I always have."

The words hung between them, fragile but real, and in that moment, Mydei wasn't sure if he should feel relieved or angrier than ever. His heart twisted in his chest as he stared at Phainon, the man who had both broken and healed him in so many ways. The kiss, the apology, the confessions—they were all too much, too fast.

And yet, despite it all, he felt something like hope. Maybe not yet healing, but something that was starting to feel like the beginning.

But before he could say anything else, Phainon moved again. His hands came up to Mydei's face, his fingers warm against his skin as he cupped Mydei's jaw, pulling him in with a quiet urgency. This time, when their lips met, it wasn't just a kiss—it was a promise, an unspoken apology, a way of showing that words weren't enough anymore.

Mydei froze for a second, his mind whirling, but then he couldn't help himself. He kissed Phainon back. It was messy and desperate and raw, but it felt real. And that was all that mattered right now.

Slipping out of the stadium unnoticed wasn't easy, but Phainon had done it before. Mydei barely had time to process what was happening before Phainon grabbed his wrist, leading him through a side exit, away from the noise of post-game interviews and the crowd still lingering outside.

The air was thick with tension—silent, charged, and filled with everything left unsaid. Mydei's mind was racing, still trying to catch up with what had just happened. Phainon had kissed him. Twice. And then apologized like his absence hadn't torn a hole straight through Mydei's chest.

And now they were leaving together.

Mydei didn't know where they were going, but he let Phainon pull him through the dimly lit backstreets, his grip firm yet careful, like he was afraid Mydei would slip away if he let go. They barely spoke on the way, their hurried footsteps the only sound between them. Phainon kept his head down, leading the way with the kind of urgency that sent heat curling through Mydei's spine. He didn't know if it was frustration or something else entirely, but his body was buzzing with it.

By the time they reached the hotel Phainon was staying at, Mydei had enough time to wonder if this was a bad idea. If he should turn back, say something, ask what the hell they were even doing. But the second the door clicked shut behind them, all of that thinking flew straight out the window.

Because the moment they were alone, Phainon was on him.

He didn’t hesitate, didn’t second-guess. He grabbed Mydei’s face with both hands and crashed their mouths together like he was afraid this would be his last chance. Mydei barely had time to inhale before Phainon’s lips were on his, insistent, desperate, almost rough with need. He stumbled back slightly, caught off guard, but Phainon followed, pressing forward, chasing the kiss like it was something he couldn’t afford to lose again.

Heat curled through Mydei’s chest, down his spine, settling somewhere deep in his gut. He felt Phainon’s hands gripping his jaw, thumbs brushing against his cheekbones, fingers threading into his hair like he was grounding himself. The way Phainon kissed him was reckless, like he had been holding this back for months, and now that the floodgates had opened, he couldn’t stop himself.

Mydei should have pulled away. Should have asked for answers, should have made Phainon work for this after months of silence. But his resolve shattered the second Phainon made a quiet, desperate sound against his mouth. That was all it took. Mydei exhaled sharply through his nose and kissed back, harder this time, pushing into Phainon like he wanted to hurt him with it.

It was messy. Uncoordinated. Too much teeth, too much heat, but Mydei didn’t care. If Phainon wanted this—if he *really* wanted this—then Mydei wasn’t going to hold back.

His back hit the wall, Phainon’s hands bracketing either side of his head, his body pressing against him, solid and warm and infuriatingly familiar. Phainon broke the kiss only long enough to look at him, breathing hard, his pupils blown wide. “I missed you,” he said, voice rough, like the words had been dragged out of him.

Something in Mydei’s chest clenched painfully. He wanted to believe him. God, he wanted to believe him so badly. But his mind still spun with everything that had come before this. Months of silence. Being blocked. Feeling like he had lost Phainon for good.

“Funny way of showing it,” Mydei said, voice sharp despite the way his breath was still uneven.

Phainon flinched slightly, but he didn’t back away. Instead, he pressed their foreheads together, eyes shutting briefly. “I know,” he admitted. “I fucked up, I *know* . I just—” He exhaled shakily, then pulled back just enough to meet Mydei’s gaze again. “I didn’t know what to do. I didn’t know what I was supposed to say to you after everything.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “So you just blocked me? Like that was the best option?”

Phainon’s jaw tightened, regret flickering across his expression. “I was scared,” he admitted, barely above a whisper. “Of what this meant. Of what you meant. And I handled it like a fucking coward.”

The raw honesty in his voice caught Mydei off guard. His fingers curled into fists at his sides, tension still coiled tight in his chest.

“You hurt me, Phainon,” he said, and it came out quieter than he intended. “I waited for you. I kept waiting and waiting for you to say something. To tell me *why* you left me in the dark like that.” His voice wavered, bitterness creeping in. “And now you think you can just kiss me and fix it?”

Phainon’s expression twisted, something pained flashing across his face. He exhaled sharply, taking a step back, finally giving Mydei space.

“No,” he said, shaking his head. “I don’t think that. I just—” He ran a hand through his hair, looking frustrated with himself. “I don’t *know* how to fix it. But I want to try.”

Mydei stared at him, trying to ignore the way his heart ached at those words. He hated how much he wanted to believe him. Hated how much he still *wanted* him, even after everything.

Phainon swallowed hard. “Tell me what to do,” he said quietly. “Tell me how to make this right.”

Mydei let out a slow, measured breath, his head still spinning. He didn’t have an answer for that. Not yet. Not when everything felt so raw.

But one thing was clear: Phainon *wanted* this. And for the first time in a long time, Mydei wasn’t sure if he was strong enough to push him away.

Silence stretched between them, heavy and uncertain. Mydei lowered himself onto the edge of the bed, bracing his elbows on his knees. He should leave. He should . His mind screamed at him to put distance between them, to protect himself before Phainon had the chance to hurt him again.

But then Phainon moved.

Without a word, he sank to his knees.

Mydei’s breath hitched. He watched, frozen, as Phainon positioned himself between his legs, pressing his forehead against Mydei’s lap like some kind of silent prayer. His hands found Mydei’s—grasping one of them, holding it like it was the only thing anchoring him to the world.

“I’m sorry,” Phainon murmured against the fabric of Mydei’s pants, his voice barely above a whisper. “I’m so fucking sorry.”

Mydei stared down at him, chest tight, heart pounding. His free hand hovered uncertainly before hesitantly settling on Phainon’s hair, fingers threading through the strands. It was an automatic, familiar motion—one he had done countless times before, back when things were simple. Back when he hadn’t felt like his heart was being wrung dry.

Phainon exhaled shakily at the touch, gripping Mydei’s hand tighter.

“I thought I could let go,” he admitted, voice raw. “I thought I could just… move on. That it would be easier if I just stopped talking to you.” He let out a bitter, breathless laugh. “But I *couldn’t* . I was miserable without you. I —” His voice broke for a fraction of a second. “I missed you so much, Mydei.”

Mydei clenched his jaw, swallowing down the lump in his throat. He wanted to stay angry. He should stay angry. But Phainon's weight against him, the warmth of his hands, the desperation in his voice—it chipped away at every wall he had built.

"You *left* me," Mydei finally said, quiet but firm. "You made me think I was nothing to you. Like I was just—something you could throw away the second it got too complicated."

Phainon flinched, guilt twisting his features. He looked up then, eyes dark and vulnerable, and Mydei hated how much it made his heart clench.

"I never meant to," Phainon said, gripping Mydei's hand tighter. "I never meant to hurt you like that."

And maybe it wasn't enough. Maybe an apology couldn't fix everything. But as Mydei stared down at the man who had torn him apart, who was now on his knees in front of him, his breath uneven and his hands trembling, he felt something shift.

Maybe Phainon *really* was scared. Maybe he had been running just as much as Mydei had been chasing.

And maybe—for the first time in months—Phainon had finally stopped running.

Phainon's grip on his hand was steady, warm, grounding. Mydei should've pulled away. Should've told him that an apology wasn't enough. That he wasn't just going to forget months of silence and hurt just because Phainon had finally stopped running.

But he didn't move.

Instead, his fingers stayed tangled in Phainon's hair, the strands soft beneath his touch. Phainon's breath was warm against his thigh, every exhale sending a slow ache curling through his stomach.

“I missed you,” Phainon murmured again, his voice lower this time, rougher. His fingers brushed over Mydei’s wrist, tracing the faint lines of his veins as if relearning the shape of him. “I tried not to.” A pause. “I failed.”

Mydei’s throat went dry.

This wasn’t fair. This—this *proximity* , the weight of Phainon’s body between his legs, the way his voice had dropped into something dangerously soft—it wasn’t fair. Not when Mydei had spent months trying to hate him. Trying to move on, trying to believe that Phainon had done the same.

And yet Phainon was here, on his knees, looking at him like he was something irreplaceable. Like letting him go had been the biggest mistake of his life.

Mydei swallowed hard. “You think saying that fixes anything?”

Phainon exhaled, tilting his head against Mydei’s lap, lips barely ghosting over the fabric of his pants. The touch was featherlight—almost accidental—but it sent a sharp jolt through Mydei’s spine.

“No,” Phainon admitted, his mouth so close that Mydei could feel every word. “But it’s the truth.”

Mydei’s fingers twitched in his hair. He needed to move. Needed to push him away before this went somewhere he wasn’t sure he could come back from.

But Phainon’s hands slid up, one resting on Mydei’s thigh, thumb pressing just enough to make his breath catch. The other traced the inside of his wrist, slow and deliberate, as if memorizing him all over again.

It wasn’t fair.

“Phainon,” Mydei started, meaning to tell him to *stop* , to back off, to—

But then Phainon looked up, and whatever was left of Mydei's self-control snapped.

His eyes were dark, hooded with something unspoken, something raw. His lips were slightly parted, his breath shallow, and god, Mydei hated him. Hated the way he could unravel him so easily. Hated the way every look, every touch, every lingering second made his pulse stutter.

Phainon shifted forward, his knee pressing between Mydei's legs now, his breath warm against his stomach as he looked up through dark lashes.

"I shouldn't have left," Phainon murmured, thumb stroking slow circles against his thigh. "I should've stayed."

Mydei clenched his jaw. His whole body was tense, coiled so tightly he felt like he might snap.

"You should've," he said, his voice coming out rough. "But you didn't."

Phainon's grip tightened just slightly—barely enough to notice, but Mydei *did* . His lips parted, but whatever he was about to say died in his throat.

Because Phainon was still looking at him like that.

Like he was something Phainon *wanted.*

And Mydei—Mydei was so *fucking* tired of pretending he didn't want him back.

Phainon's breath was uneven now, his hands still on Mydei's thighs, his thumbs pressing just enough to make Mydei feel grounded —or maybe just trapped. He should've told him to back off. Should've shoved him away before this got worse, before it became something he couldn't just walk away from.

But Mydei didn't move.

Didn't push him off when Phainon's fingers curled against the muscle of his thigh, when his grip tightened, when he shifted even closer, his mouth

barely an inch away from where Mydei's shirt had ridden up.

"I should've stayed," Phainon repeated, voice lower now, thick with something Mydei didn't dare name. His breath ghosted over Mydei's skin, a slow burn following wherever it touched.

And then—then he *leaned* in.

It was barely a touch, just the faintest brush of Phainon's lips against the sensitive skin above Mydei's waistband, but it hit like a fucking *shockwave* .

Mydei's breath stuttered, his fingers tightening in Phainon's hair before he could stop himself. Before he could pretend this wasn't affecting him. Before he could stop the sharp exhale that left him, a sound he hadn't meant to make, not *this easily* , not for *him* .

Phainon stilled at that—just for a second. Then his lips curled against Mydei's skin, and fuck— *fuck* —he was *smirking* .

"You want me to stop?" Phainon murmured, voice almost teasing but something softer beneath it, something unsure. His lips brushed against Mydei's stomach again, warmer this time, more deliberate. "Just say the word."

Mydei clenched his jaw. He could end this. Could shove Phainon off, stand up, walk out, pretend none of this ever happened.

But Phainon was still looking up at him, still *on his knees* , still touching him like he wasn't planning on stopping unless *Mydei* was the one to make him.

And Mydei—he wasn't sure he *wanted* to stop.

Not when Phainon's hands had started moving again, sliding up, fingertips ghosting over his ribs. Not when his lips had parted just slightly, as if he was waiting for permission to keep *going* .

Not when Mydei had spent *years wanting this*.

He should say something. Should push him away. Should—

Phainon's fingers curled around his hip, his mouth pressing just a little *lower* , and Mydei felt something sharp claw up his spine, something *dangerous* , something he couldn't just ignore.

His breathing was uneven now, his pulse *wrecked* , his body betraying him in ways he didn't even want to acknowledge.

Phainon must've noticed.

Because his grip tightened, and his voice was lower when he asked, "Still mad at me?"

And *fuck* him for that. *Fuck* him for knowing *exactly* what he was doing.

"Yeah," Mydei breathed, voice rough, strained.

Phainon hummed, and Mydei felt the vibration of it all the way through him.

"Good," Phainon murmured, and then—

Then he *bit* him.

Just above the waistband of his jeans, right on the sharp lines of his hip. Not hard, not enough to hurt, but enough to tease , enough to make Mydei suck in a sharp breath, enough to make something hot coil in the pit of his stomach.

His grip in Phainon's hair *tightened* , and Phainon exhaled sharply at that, like maybe *he* wasn't as in control as he thought.

The thought made something shift in Mydei's chest, something dark and reckless and *needy* , and he should stop this. He *should.*

But instead, his voice came out lower, quieter.

“You’re such a *bastard* ,” he muttered, fingers still tangled in Phainon’s hair.

Phainon only smirked. “Yeah,” he said, lips dragging over Mydei’s skin, hot and teasing. “But you like me like this.”

And the worst part?

The *worst* fucking part?

He was *right.*

Phainon’s smirk was sharp, but there was something almost *desperate* in the way he gripped Mydei’s waist, like he needed something solid to hold onto. Mydei should have shoved him off, should have sneered at him, should have done *anything* but let his fingers tighten in Phainon’s hair, tugging just enough to make him hiss.

But Mydei had never been good at *walking away* from him.

Phainon’s mouth was still on him, burning against every inch of exposed skin, and every breath Mydei took felt heavier, hotter, harder to control. His pulse was wrecked, his body already betraying him in ways he didn’t even want to name .

Phainon must have felt it too.

Because instead of backing off, instead of stopping, his hands *slid higher* . Fingers curling under the hem of Mydei’s shirt, dragging it up, barely giving Mydei a second to react before his mouth was on him again.

And *fuck*—it wasn’t enough.

Mydei’s breath hitched, his muscles tensing as Phainon pressed a slow, open-mouthed kiss just beneath his ribs, his lips unbearably warm against Mydei’s skin.

“You still mad?” Phainon murmured, his breath ghosting against him, teasing, testing, like he was waiting for Mydei to snap.

“You blocked me for *months*,” Mydei ground out, voice strained.

Phainon hummed, trailing his lips lower . “I know,” he said, voice softer now, less teasing. His fingers pressed against Mydei’s sides, firm, like he didn’t want to let go. “I shouldn’t have.”

That was an understatement. A ridiculous, stupid understatement, but Mydei could barely focus on that, not when Phainon’s mouth was pressing against his stomach again, moving slow, careful, deliberate in a way that felt almost like an apology.

It wasn’t an apology.

But fuck if Mydei didn’t want to pretend it *was*.

His fingers twitched in Phainon’s hair, a sharp tug making Phainon groan —low, rough, wrecked—and Mydei felt the sound all the way through him.

“You’re such a *fucking coward*, ” Mydei muttered, breath uneven.

Phainon exhaled sharply, and for the first time, *his* grip faltered.

“Yeah,” Phainon murmured, pressing his forehead against Mydei’s stomach. His voice was quieter now, something almost uncertain in it. “I know.”

His hands slid up Mydei’s sides again, slower this time, like he was trying to memorize the shape of him.

It made something ache in Mydei’s chest, something he didn’t want to acknowledge, something too dangerous .

He should push him away.

But instead, his fingers tightened, pulling Phainon’s head back just enough to make him look up.

Phainon’s lips were red now, his breathing just as uneven as Mydei’s, his pupils blown wide in the dim light of the room.

And then, softer—quieter—like maybe he was finally saying something *real* —Phainon asked,

“You still want me?”

And *fuck*, Mydei wished he didn’t.

But he did.

Mydei’s chest tightened, and for a split second, he wanted to shove those feelings back down, stuff them back into the box he’d sealed them in months ago. The box he’d locked up with a combination of anger, resentment, and guilt. But Phainon’s gaze was *so wide , so needy* , that it shattered the flimsy walls Mydei had tried to build.

He swallowed, voice rougher than he intended as he answered. “I never stopped wanting you.”

Phainon’s breath caught at that, a faint tremor in his hands as they hovered over Mydei’s waist, as if waiting for permission.

Mydei didn’t give him time to hesitate. He pulled him in, mouth crashing against Phainon’s again, no more games, no more teasing. This kiss was hard , urgent, full of every ounce of frustration that had built up over the last few months. Every moment they had missed, every moment Phainon had blocked him, every thing that had felt like it would suffocate him.

Phainon moaned into the kiss, his hands sliding up, pulling Mydei closer, pressing him against the solid heat of his body. Mydei felt the rapid beat of Phainon’s heart under his fingers, felt how his body was just as needy , just as desperate.

Mydei needed more, needed it all , so he let his hands roam, grabbing at Phainon’s clothes, pulling at the fabric, needing the contact, needing the heat of him.

Phainon’s breath hitched, pulling back for just a second to catch his breath. His lips were swollen, his eyes clouded with want. “You sure about this?”

Mydei could barely think straight, let alone answer, but he nodded. “Yeah,” he rasped, fingers digging into Phainon’s shirt. “I’m sure.”

Phainon’s mouth was back on him in an instant, kissing him harder, pressing him backward toward the bed. Every move was deliberate, but desperate at the same time—like he was trying to hold on, trying not to break everything they’d built up between them in one go.

But Mydei didn’t want to hold back anymore.

Before he knew it, they were both on the bed, clothes discarded in a rush, the air between them charged with raw, unspoken tension. Phainon’s hands traced every line of Mydei’s body like he was mapping him out, reacquainting himself with the feel of him, the texture of his skin. And Mydei couldn’t get enough of it, couldn’t get enough of Phainon’s touch, of how he knew exactly where to press, how to touch, how to make Mydei’s entire body *shiver* .

Phainon’s lips moved down Mydei’s neck, leaving a trail of heat in their wake, and Mydei’s breath hitched. “Phainon—” He couldn’t even finish his thought, not when Phainon’s mouth was pressing against his chest, his hands sliding down his sides to undo his belt, to make him feel *everything* .

Mydei gasped when he felt Phainon’s lips at his collarbone, biting down just enough to send a jolt of pleasure through him. “You’re still so fucking perfect,” Phainon muttered, voice rougher than it had ever been, each word full of the same intensity that burned in Mydei’s chest.

He couldn’t stop the shiver that ran down his spine. “I’m not perfect.”

Phainon paused, looking up at him with a gaze so intense it felt like it could burn. “Don’t say that,” he whispered, voice softer than before. “Not when I know exactly what I want.”

Phainon leaned up, brushing his lips against Mydei’s, slow and tender, and the world seemed to slow with it, like time was giving them a moment to breathe before everything spiraled out of control.

Mydei leaned into the kiss, his hands coming up to cup Phainon's face, as if trying to hold him steady. Trying to hold himself steady.

But there was no steadying anymore.

Not with Phainon here, not with his body on top of Mydei's, not with the air between them electric, alive.

Mydei's hands slid to the back of Phainon's neck, tugging him down again, pulling him closer. "No more running, Phainon," Mydei breathed, his voice thick, heavy. "Not from me."

Phainon's eyes flickered with something deep, something dark, and before Mydei could question it, Phainon's hands were on his waist again, lifting him, adjusting him just enough to slip between his legs, careful of his injuries of course, before finally pressing into him.

The contact was enough to have Mydei gasping, every nerve in his body lighting up.

"I'm not running," Phainon whispered back, his voice low, serious, and *unwavering* . "Not this time."

And just like that, everything else faded away. The world, the consequences, the months of silence—all of it was *nothing* .

Because Phainon was here, and Mydei had let him back in.

Phainon was impossibly close, his body a firm weight over Mydei's. The heat of it was overwhelming, each movement controlled, careful, but there was an edge to it. The need, the hunger, it was there, building.

"Mydei," Phainon breathed against his lips, his voice low and strained, a stark contrast to the soft intensity of their kiss. Phainon's hands slid down, finding the waistband of Mydei's pants, his fingers working the button open, but there was hesitation there, as if testing Mydei's reaction, seeking permission.

Mydei’s breath hitched, his body responding instinctively, even if his mind was still reeling from everything that had happened. “Take it slow,” Mydei whispered, his voice shaky, both from the intensity of the moment and the vulnerability he felt. His hand trailed up to Phainon’s chest, fingers splayed against his skin as he pushed gently. “My knee—”

Phainon didn’t need more than that. His lips ghosted over Mydei’s skin, a trail of soft kisses down his jaw, his neck, stopping at the junction of his shoulder. He shifted, giving Mydei the space he needed, but then he was right there, hovering just above him, eyes dark with an emotion Mydei couldn’t quite place.

“Don’t worry about it,” Phainon said softly, his lips brushing over Mydei’s ear, his voice a whispered promise. “I’ve got you.”

And he did.

Phainon’s hand slid beneath Mydei’s shirt again, moving gently but with purpose, fingers tracing over the muscles of Mydei’s abdomen, up his sides. Mydei’s body arched involuntarily toward him, his breath hitching as Phainon’s lips found his throat again, kissing, sucking gently, making him ache in ways he hadn’t expected.

“God, you’re so beautiful,” Phainon muttered against his skin, the words like a drug, feeding into the heat that was already building between them. His hand slid down to Mydei’s thigh, gentle but insistent, guiding it to rest over his own, ensuring that the leg that had betrayed him didn’t have to carry the weight. Phainon was careful, always so fucking careful with him.

The shift in position allowed Mydei to press up into him, to feel every inch of Phainon’s body, warm and firm, against his own. He wanted this—wanted him—so badly it made his chest tighten with need.

“You’re killing me,” Mydei muttered, voice ragged, as Phainon’s touch continued to trail lower, teasing at the waistband of his pants. He gasped as Phainon’s lips found their way back to his, slow and deep, the kiss turning hotter, desperate, as their bodies shifted together.

“Mydei,” Phainon whispered against his lips again, the name a plea, a statement, a sound that made Mydei ache. “I need you so much.”

Phainon’s hand traveled lower, grazing over Mydei’s clothed body, teasing, before he pulled back slightly, looking down at Mydei with a mixture of wonder and something less than innocent. “Tell me if I hurt you,” he murmured, his voice steady but tight, as if every word was carefully chosen. His hand moved with slow precision, like he was savoring every moment, every inch of Mydei’s skin that he could touch.

“I’ll be fine,” Mydei breathed, his hands gripping Phainon’s shoulders, needing the stability, the connection. “Just—fuck, take it slow with me.”

The tension in the room shifted, thick and charged, as Phainon shifted, carefully adjusting his position so Mydei’s leg was comfortably supported, his body never straying far. The heat between them grew, but Phainon’s carefulness never wavered, despite the way his hands shook with desire.

Every movement they shared was a mixture of tenderness and urgency. Mydei’s heart raced, but it wasn’t just from the physical closeness. It was from the emotions he was struggling to hold back—the years of pain, of longing, of all the things he’d buried that now threatened to rise to the surface.

Phainon’s lips brushed against his ear, a soft, slow whisper as his hands roamed lower again. “Tell me what you need,” he murmured, his voice breaking through the fog of Mydei’s mind. “Tell me how to make you feel good.”

Mydei closed his eyes, shaking his head as his body responded to the warmth of Phainon’s touch, the way he moved with such precision, such care. He wanted to give in. He wanted to lose himself in this, in Phainon, who had always been the only one who made him feel whole again.

“You already are,” Mydei managed, his voice barely a whisper as his hand slid to Phainon’s chest, pushing him back just enough to catch his breath.

But Phainon wasn’t having it. He shifted again, and this time, the kiss that followed was heated, urgent, as if they were both trying to catch up to the moments they had lost. Mydei’s breath hitched as Phainon’s hand slid over his body once more, the way his fingers traced every curve, every part of him, made him feel alive in a way he hadn’t in so long.

“I won’t hurt you,” Phainon promised again, his voice almost a whisper as he pulled Mydei closer, if that was even possible. “But I need you, Mydei. Please. Let me—”

“Mydei,” Phainon breathed again, his lips at Mydei’s throat, pressing just hard enough to make him gasp. “Let me make this right.”

Mydei’s chest tightened, his knee throbbing slightly, but all he could focus on was Phainon’s body, the way it moved against his. He needed this. Needed *him* .

With a deep breath, Mydei let go, wrapping his arms around Phainon’s neck, pulling him down, feeling the weight of him, the steady presence that grounded him in the middle of everything. This was more than he could’ve ever asked for.

“I’m here,” Phainon murmured, lips brushing against his ear. “And I’m not going anywhere.”

Phainon’s fingers traveled lower, moving with practiced ease as he gently spread Mydei’s legs, positioning himself between them. He reached for the lube, coating his fingers with a generous amount. His thumb brushed over Mydei’s entrance, slow and careful, making sure he was prepared before moving further.

“Just breathe,” Phainon murmured, brushing Mydei’s hair away from his face. “We’ll go slow, okay?”

Mydei’s breath quickened, but he nodded, his grip tightening on Phainon’s shoulder as he adjusted himself. Every part of him wanted this, needed it, but the vulnerability still held him back. Phainon’s thumb pressed gently,

circling slowly, and Mydei's muscles tensed before relaxing, easing into the sensation.

"You're so good for me," Phainon praised quietly, his fingers beginning to move inside Mydei, stretching him slowly. "Just like that."

Mydei swallowed hard, the praise sending a sharp, unexpected heat through him. He never thought he'd be the type for it, but now, in this moment, he couldn't help the way his body responded to Phainon's words. Every shift, every touch felt like a promise, and the vulnerability he'd tried to push down was unraveling with every whisper Phainon gave him.

Phainon's lips returned to his neck, kissing the skin there as he slowly worked his fingers, pushing deeper, all while watching Mydei's reactions closely. The way Mydei's breath hitched, the way his body responded to the slow build-up, it drove him mad.

"Shh… you're doing so well," Phainon murmured, pressing a soft kiss to Mydei's jaw. "Just a little more."

Mydei groaned softly, his grip tightening. "I can't believe I let myself go this long without you," he admitted, the words slipping from his lips before he could stop them. He closed his eyes, trying to quiet the torrent of emotions flooding through him. It felt so good, but the vulnerability—the trust he was giving Phainon—was almost overwhelming.

"You're not alone now," Phainon whispered back, voice thick with sincerity. "I won't let you be."

The intimacy of it, the softness, was almost unbearable. Phainon slowly added another finger, stretching him with careful precision. Mydei winced slightly, but the discomfort was brief. Phainon's touch was constant, never rushed, guiding him through every step.

Then, Phainon's lips found Mydei's again, a kiss that started tender but quickly deepened, the pressure building between them. Mydei responded, his hand moving to Phainon's hair, pulling him closer, needing more.

And when Phainon finally pulled his fingers free, Mydei felt empty for a moment, but the aching hunger inside him only grew.

“I want you, Phainon,” Mydei breathed, voice rough, as he shifted slightly, careful of his knee. “Please.”

Phainon gave him a gentle smile, his eyes dark with desire but still holding that edge of tenderness. He leaned in, his lips brushing Mydei’s forehead.

“I’ve got you,” Phainon promised, his hand gently cupping Mydei’s knee, guiding it carefully, ensuring he was comfortable as he aligned himself. Mydei felt his heart beat faster, the anticipation almost too much to handle.

“Relax,” Phainon murmured as he slowly pushed in, inch by inch, giving Mydei a chance to adjust, to breathe.

The initial sting was sharp, but it didn’t last. Phainon was careful, patient, ensuring every movement was steady, guiding Mydei to relax and take him in.

“You’re doing so well,” Phainon whispered again, praise flooding Mydei’s ears. “So good for me. So beautiful.”

It wasn’t just the physical pleasure anymore; it was the way Phainon’s words made him feel. Worth it. Seen. Needed. It was the emotional vulnerability that made everything feel sharper, more intense. Mydei’s leg still ached, but Phainon’s hand on his knee, the way he shifted to avoid pressure, made it bearable. He was aware of his injury, but it felt like Phainon was making space for him to feel everything else.

“Mydei,” Phainon whispered, his voice a low rasp as he moved, his pace slow but deliberate. “I’m not going anywhere. You’ve got me, all of me, as much as you want.”

Mydei let out a shaky breath, his fingers digging into Phainon’s skin as his body responded, taking what Phainon gave him. His injury, his past, none of it mattered right now. All that mattered was this moment—being with Phainon.

Phainon's slow pace was driving Mydei mad. He could feel every inch of him, stretching him open, the pressure building in ways he wasn't prepared for. His hands gripped the sheets, nails digging in as Phainon shifted above him, making sure every movement was slow, deliberate, but oh, so intense.

"Look at me," Phainon whispered, voice rough. "I want to see your face."

Mydei's eyes fluttered shut, his body shuddering as the pressure continued to grow. Phainon was stretching him in ways he hadn't felt in so long, and it wasn't all the way in yet—just enough to make him feel like his body was unraveling. Phainon was too damn big, too overwhelming, and Mydei could barely catch his breath, each drag of Phainon's hips sending jolts of heat coursing through him.

His back arched as Phainon shifted again, the motion sending sparks of pleasure mixed with just enough discomfort to make him moan, unable to control the reaction.

"You like that, huh?" Phainon's voice was low, husky, a wicked smirk in his tone. His hand slid down Mydei's body, lightly brushing against his stomach, pressing lightly, almost teasing.

Mydei's face flushed with embarrassment. He never showed this side of himself—never let anyone see how much this was affecting him. But Phainon's words, his voice, they hit him in a way he didn't expect. A soft breath left his lips, his head tilting slightly away from Phainon, trying to hide the vulnerability threatening to swallow him.

But Phainon wasn't having it. He leaned down, his hand gently cupping Mydei's jaw, guiding his face back up. "Look at me," he repeated, his voice firm but not unkind. "I want to see everything."

Mydei hesitated, then slowly opened his eyes, locking gazes with Phainon. The intensity in his stare was enough to pull Mydei further in, the emotions that had been building between them these past few months flooding to the surface. He couldn't hide anymore, couldn't keep pretending he wasn't breaking at the edges.

“That’s it,” Phainon murmured, his voice softer now, but still carrying that same intensity. He pressed in deeper, just enough to make Mydei’s body jerk beneath him, to feel every inch of the strain that came with the stretch. Mydei’s breath caught, and he couldn’t suppress the soft moan that escaped his throat.

Phainon watched him closely, his movements slow, giving Mydei time to adjust, but his eyes never left his face. He needed to see how Mydei responded to him. Needed to feel him react—needed to know that Mydei was with him, entirely.

Mydei’s fingers curled into Phainon’s arm, his body trembling under the pressure. “Fuck, Phainon,” he groaned, voice breaking slightly. “It’s too much.”

Phainon’s lips quirked into a knowing smile, though there was a softness to it now. “I know,” he whispered, pressing his forehead against Mydei’s. “But you’re doing so well for me. You’re taking it so well, just like I knew you would.”

Mydei wanted to look away again, but Phainon kept his gaze steady, his hand on Mydei’s chest, feeling the rapid beat of his heart.

“You’re gorgeous like this,” Phainon murmured, his voice thick with both admiration and lust. “So fucking gorgeous. You’ve got no idea how badly I’ve wanted this.”

Every word felt like a spark, igniting something deep inside Mydei. It wasn’t just physical anymore. It was the way Phainon made him feel, like he was enough, like he was seen in ways he hadn’t been in years.

Phainon’s lips found his again, kissing him deeply, his hands moving to Mydei’s legs, gently adjusting him so he could move deeper. Mydei gasped into the kiss, the sensation overwhelming him, but at the same time, there was something incredibly comforting about how carefully Phainon was treating him—despite how intense the whole situation had become.

“You’re not gonna break,” Phainon promised, his voice warm in Mydei’s ear. “You’re gonna take all of me. I know you can.”

And Mydei—lost, confused, and more vulnerable than he’d ever been—couldn’t help but believe him.

Phainon’s hands remained steady on Mydei’s body, a firm but gentle grip as he slowly pulled out, giving Mydei a moment to breathe. Mydei’s chest was rising and falling rapidly, his body still trembling from the pressure, but as he looked at Phainon, something inside him clicked. He needed to take control, needed to feel more of Phainon, but this time, it had to be on his terms, with careful precision, mindful of his leg.

“Let me—let me try something,” Mydei muttered, his voice breathless, but with a note of determination. Phainon gave him a slow, questioning look, and Mydei shifted, slowly pushing himself up to sit, careful not to strain his leg. His hands braced against Phainon’s shoulders, fingers curling into the fabric of his shirt for support. Phainon watched him intently, his expression softening as he let Mydei take the lead.

Mydei could feel the warmth of Phainon’s body against him, the closeness between them growing even more tangible. He carefully adjusted himself, lifting his hips just slightly before lowering himself slowly onto Phainon, making sure to go at his own pace.

The first stretch was enough to make him gasp, his head tilting back at the feeling of being filled again. It was more controlled this time, more deliberate, and his hands gripped Phainon’s shoulders tighter as he slowly settled fully, feeling the fullness and the heat of Phainon deep inside him. He bit his lip, fighting against the sensation of being overwhelmed by how much Phainon had taken up space inside him.

“I’ve got you,” Phainon murmured, his hands gentle on Mydei’s sides, but not moving. He was letting Mydei set the pace, giving him the control, and Mydei was grateful for that. He took a steadying breath, focusing on how he could move without straining his leg, adjusting his posture to relieve any pressure on his knee. His leg was carefully propped up at an angle that felt

comfortable—he wasn’t going to let it hold him back, not when he needed to feel this connection.

Phainon’s hands slid down to his thighs, helping guide him as Mydei began to rock his hips, slowly at first, building a rhythm that felt natural, that didn’t push him past what he could handle. Each movement was a careful balance, but as Mydei found the rhythm, the discomfort of his injury became secondary to the pleasure that built between them.

Phainon’s breathing became deeper, his hands gripping Mydei’s hips more firmly, guiding his motions as Mydei moved above him. Mydei couldn’t stop the moan that slipped from his lips as the pressure built, his body humming with the sensations of Phainon’s weight beneath him, the friction as he slowly moved up and down.

“You feel so good,” Phainon murmured, his voice thick with desire. “You’re doing so well for me.”

Mydei’s breath hitched at the praise, the words sinking deep into his chest, lighting up parts of him he hadn’t realized were craving that kind of validation. He leaned forward slightly, supporting himself on Phainon’s chest as he shifted his hips, changing the angle just enough to send waves of pleasure crashing through him.

Phainon’s fingers tightened around Mydei’s hips, the grip both firm and reassuring, and Mydei found himself focusing on his movements, trying to stay in control but completely overwhelmed by the way Phainon’s body responded beneath him. His head tipped back again, his eyes fluttering shut as he concentrated on his own rhythm, trying not to go too fast, not to push his body beyond what it could handle.

But the intensity of the moment, the way Phainon was encouraging him, it was almost too much. “Fuck, Phainon,” Mydei gasped, his breath coming out in ragged bursts as his body shuddered with each movement.

Phainon’s hands moved up to his chest, gently pushing him back up so that Mydei was sitting upright, his chest exposed, the pressure on his leg relieved by the new position. “Look at me,” Phainon whispered again, his

eyes locked on Mydei's, full of heat and something deeper that Mydei couldn't quite name. "You're amazing."

Mydei's heart was pounding in his chest, and with Phainon's steadying touch, he found the rhythm again. He moved slowly at first, then with increasing confidence, pushing himself higher, letting the sensation of their bodies meeting drive him forward. There was nothing but the feeling of Phainon beneath him, the way their bodies were moving together, the slow, deliberate push and pull.

Mydei's breath caught as the pressure in his core grew, his body trembling as he moved, his leg carefully held, still aware of the injury but willing to push through it, to feel this connection between them, to experience something he thought he had lost forever.

And with every motion, every stroke, he could feel Phainon's hands guiding him, steadying him, helping him find his balance. It wasn't about rushing—it was about savoring the moment. And Mydei let himself fall into it completely.

Phainon had been content to watch, his hands steady on Mydei's hips as he let him take what he needed, his gaze dark with admiration and hunger. He didn't rush, didn't interrupt—he just let Mydei move, let him work through the pleasure, taking in every sharp breath, every shuddering moan, every delicate tremor in his body. The way Mydei held onto him, the way his lips parted in bliss, his skin flushed with exertion—it was enough to undo Phainon entirely.

But then, something shifted. Mydei's movements slowed, his muscles trembling from the strain, his breaths coming in short, ragged bursts. Phainon could see the way his body tensed, the way he was holding himself up despite the exhaustion creeping in. And as much as Phainon had loved every second of watching him like this—so raw, so open—he wasn't going to let Mydei push himself past his limits.

Gently, he reached up, steadying Mydei's waist before leaning in, his lips brushing against the sweat-slick skin of Mydei's collarbone. "Let me take care of you," he murmured, voice low and full of promise.

Mydei barely had time to react before Phainon moved, shifting their positions with care. He guided Mydei down onto his back, making sure his injured leg was settled comfortably, never jostling it too much. Mydei let out a breathy noise, his body still humming with pleasure, but there was something else now—a quiet kind of surrender, trust in Phainon to take over.

Phainon hovered over him, trailing slow kisses along Mydei's throat, down his chest, over the scars and marks left behind from years of pushing his body to its limits. His hands moved with deliberate care, sliding down Mydei's sides, over the defined muscle, mapping out every inch of him like he wanted to memorize it.

Then, he shifted lower.

His hands smoothed down Mydei's thigh, carefully avoiding any unnecessary pressure on his knee. His lips followed, pressing soft, lingering kisses down the length of his leg, his breath warm against Mydei's skin. When he reached the injured knee, he hesitated for a moment, his touch light, reverent. He could feel the tension in Mydei's muscles, the way he went still beneath him.

Phainon exhaled slowly, then pressed a feather-light kiss just above the joint.

Mydei sucked in a sharp breath, his fingers twitching against the sheets. "Phainon…" His voice was strained, but not from pain—more from something unspoken, something raw.

Phainon lifted his head, meeting Mydei's gaze. "Does it hurt?" he asked softly, fingers barely grazing the scarred area.

Mydei swallowed hard, shaking his head. "No. Just… I don't—" He stopped himself, looking away, but Phainon wasn't having that.

"Hey," Phainon murmured, leaning up to kiss the inside of Mydei's thigh, his hands still steady on him. "It's part of you. Every part of you deserves to be treated like this."

Mydei’s breath hitched, something breaking apart in his chest at the words. No one had ever touched him there like this—not with worship, not with care. He had spent years resenting this part of himself, hiding the pain behind sarcasm and stubbornness. But here Phainon was, kissing the thing that had ruined him, and Mydei didn’t know whether he wanted to melt into it or push him away before it could get to him.

Phainon didn’t give him time to decide. Instead, he moved back up, pressing a lingering kiss to Mydei’s lips, deep and slow. “I’ve got you,” he whispered against his mouth, his hands sliding back up to cradle Mydei’s face.

And then, with a steady roll of his hips, Phainon pressed back into him—this time with no rush, no urgency. Just deep, aching devotion.

Phainon moved slowly, his rhythm deep and deliberate, like he had all the time in the world to savor this. His hands never left Mydei, tracing over his skin, gripping his waist, grounding him in every way possible. There was no rush anymore—no battle for control, no lingering frustration. Just this. Just them.

Mydei felt like he was unraveling, every slow thrust dragging pleasure through his body like fire licking at his veins. He had spent years pretending he didn’t need this, that he was fine, that he could live without Phainon pressed against him, holding him like he was something precious. But he couldn’t—not really.

His hands slid up Phainon’s back, nails digging in just enough to make Phainon shudder against him. He felt every tremor in Phainon’s body, the way his breath came out uneven, like he was barely holding on himself.

Phainon leaned down, his lips brushing against Mydei’s ear. “I can’t believe I let myself go this long without you,” he murmured, voice wrecked, like the thought itself physically hurt.

Mydei let out a shaky breath, his fingers tightening in Phainon’s hair, pulling him closer. “Then don’t do it again,” he whispered back, his voice raw, vulnerable in a way he rarely let himself be.

Phainon stilled for a moment, just barely, like the words had hit deeper than anything else. Then he kissed Mydei—deep and consuming, a silent promise.

The rest unraveled in a blur of heat and movement, their bodies pressed together, their breathing in sync. Mydei barely noticed when he finally tipped over the edge, his back arching as pleasure crashed through him. Phainon followed soon after, his grip on Mydei tightening as he buried his face against his neck, groaning low and rough.

For a long time, neither of them moved. Just the sound of their breathing filled the room, both of them still tangled together, limbs heavy with exhaustion.

Eventually, Phainon shifted, careful not to jostle Mydei's knee as he rolled to the side. His fingers skimmed over Mydei's face, pushing sweat-damp hair from his forehead before pressing a lingering kiss there.

Mydei exhaled, his body still thrumming from everything. He should say something. He should ask what the hell this meant, if Phainon still planned to disappear, if he was going to wake up in the morning and realize this was just a fleeting thing.

But for now, Phainon was here, still touching him, still holding him like he wasn't planning to let go.

So Mydei closed his eyes and let himself believe it. Just for a little while longer.

The morning sunlight filtered through the curtains, casting soft rays across the room. The air felt different this time—quiet, heavy with the weight of the night before. Mydei lay there, still tangled in the sheets with Phainon's body pressed against his, his back to Phainon's chest, the steady rhythm of his breathing warm against the back of Mydei's neck.

He hadn't realized he'd fallen asleep so deeply, but now, as the haze of exhaustion began to lift, reality started creeping in. The space between their bodies felt like the size of a canyon, the touch of Phainon's hand against his

skin making it feel even more distant. He swallowed, the weight of everything from the night before hitting him all at once.

What was this?

It couldn’t just be a one-time thing. Phainon had kissed him like he meant it. They had talked—well, Phainon had opened up more than he ever had before. But that didn’t change the fact that Phainon was, well, Phainon. A professional athlete, always traveling, always leaving.

Mydei’s knee throbbed in the silence. The reality of his injury felt sharper this morning—like a reminder that even if he could find a way to make this work, it would never be easy. He was a broken man in some ways, and no matter how badly he wanted Phainon to stay, he had to face the fact that it wasn’t as simple as that.

He turned slightly in Phainon’s arms, looking over his shoulder, eyes scanning the peaceful expression on Phainon’s face as he slept. Phainon didn’t seem to be troubled, didn’t seem to have any doubts at all. His hand was still resting lazily against Mydei’s waist, like nothing had changed.

But Mydei? He wasn’t sure of anything anymore.

Phainon stirred slightly, his arm tightening around him, pulling Mydei closer as he nuzzled against his neck. Mydei’s breath hitched. He knew that he wasn’t ready to face whatever this was—or if Phainon was, either. But there it was. He could feel it, even now. The pull between them hadn’t disappeared.

Still, he couldn’t help himself. “What are we?” The question slipped out before he could stop it, quiet but heavy in the air.

Phainon’s movements stilled, and for a long moment, neither of them spoke. Mydei felt a knot tighten in his stomach, the unease bubbling back up, and he cursed himself for asking. He shouldn’t have. He’d just… he’d let himself get carried away.

Finally, Phainon spoke, his voice groggy but laced with something deeper. “What do you want us to be?”

The question hit harder than he expected. Mydei bit his lip, unsure how to respond. He didn’t even know what he wanted, not really. Part of him wanted to fall into this—let it be easy, let it be simple. But the other part, the part of him that had been broken and discarded for so long, couldn’t shake the fear that it was all just a fleeting moment.

Phainon shifted, lifting his head slightly to meet Mydei’s gaze. His eyes were still heavy with sleep, but there was something undeniably serious in them. “Mydei, you know what my job is. I can’t promise I’ll always be here. I wish I could, but—” He sighed, looking away for a second, his expression almost too vulnerable. “But I’m not asking you to wait around for me, either. I don’t want to make that promise. I just… I want to figure this out. With you.”

Mydei’s heart hammered in his chest. Phainon’s words felt like a thread pulling at him, tugging him toward something he wasn’t sure he could handle. But God, he wanted to. He wanted to figure it out, too.

“Do you… want to try?” Mydei asked quietly, a mix of hope and fear in his voice.

Phainon’s expression softened, and he nodded. “I do.” He leaned forward, pressing a gentle kiss to Mydei’s forehead, his hand resting carefully on Mydei’s knee, cautious with the injury. “We’ll figure it out, even if it’s hard. I’m not going anywhere—well, I am,” he added with a small chuckle, “but when I come back… we’ll figure it out.”

Mydei let out a shaky breath, relief flooding through him, but there was still that part of him that wondered if this was just the calm before the storm. Could he handle this? Could they both?

“I don’t know how this works,” Mydei murmured, his voice almost fragile.

Phainon smiled, his thumb tracing over Mydei’s knuckles. “We’ll learn together.” He looked at Mydei, his gaze steady, full of conviction. “We’ll

take it one day at a time, okay?”

Mydei nodded, his chest tightening with a mix of anticipation and uncertainty. For the first time in a long time, he allowed himself to believe that maybe—just maybe—they could make this work.

Two Years Later

The stadium was filled with a roaring crowd, chants of victory echoing through the air as Phainon stood with his teammates, the championship trophy held high above his head. It had been an incredible season—a culmination of years of hard work, training, and sacrifice. The victory was sweet, but it wasn’t just about the trophy. It was about how far he had come, how much he had grown, and the people who had supported him along the way.

Later that day, after the celebrations, Phainon sat down for an interview with a sports journalist. The cameras were rolling, capturing every moment as he grinned in front of them, the championship medal still hanging around his neck. He looked every bit the part of a superstar—handsome, confident, and at the top of his game.

“So, Phainon,” the interviewer asked, clearly trying to poke into more personal territory, “you’ve had an incredible year, both on the field and off. You’ve been pretty tight-lipped about your personal life, but I have to ask… There’ve been some rumors about Cyrene. A lot of fans are hoping to see something more between you two. What’s the deal?”

Phainon’s smile never faltered, but a flicker of amusement danced in his eyes. He leaned forward slightly, a glint of mischief in his expression.

“Well, actually,” he began, letting the tension build for a moment, “I’m already in a relationship.”

The room fell silent, the interviewer blinking in shock. Phainon continued, his voice calm but dripping with certainty, “Yeah, I’ve been seeing someone for a while now. And it’s going great.” He looked straight at the camera then, a wink directed right at it.

The interviewer sputtered, clearly thrown off. “Wait, so you—”

“Yes,” Phainon cut in smoothly, “I’m with someone. Sorry to disappoint anyone hoping for a different answer, but that’s the reality.”

The reaction was immediate. The camera crew froze, their eyes wide. The journalists were scrambling for their notes, all trying to make sense of what they had just heard. It was as if the entire world had just learned the biggest secret Phainon had been keeping. And, sure enough, the news broke online within minutes, the headlines plastering across social media: Sport Legend Phainon Reveals He’s in a Relationship.

Meanwhile, across the world, Mydei sat in his living room, the soft glow of the TV casting light over his face as he watched the interview unfold. He had been following Phainon’s game, of course, but when the question about Cyrene came up, his interest piqued. And then, when Phainon casually mentioned he was in a relationship, Mydei snorted.

“Seriously?” he muttered to himself, his lips curling into a smile as Phainon winked at the camera. “Smooth, huh?”

Mydei couldn’t help the warmth that spread through him at Phainon’s subtle display of affection. It wasn’t anything outlandish, but it was enough to make Mydei feel seen. The moment had been simple, but so very Phainon —effortlessly charming and confident, letting the world know just who he was with.

Mydei lay back in bed, his thoughts still swirling from the interview he had just watched. Phainon’s casual reveal had hit him in unexpected ways—like an unspoken confirmation that all the quiet moments, all the distance, hadn’t been in vain.

He hadn’t realized how much he’d missed hearing Phainon’s voice until that very moment. Their long-distance relationship was hardly easy—some days felt endless, like the gap between them would never close. Yet somehow, they always made it work. Video calls, texts, late-night conversations—those fleeting moments when they could bridge the miles between them, when Phainon’s presence felt real, even if only for a little while.

The vibration of his phone snapped him out of his thoughts, and when he glanced down, his heart did a little skip.

Phainon.

A smile tugged at the corners of his mouth before he could stop it. He quickly swiped to answer, and the familiar warmth of his name on Phainon’s lips made everything else fade away.

“Hello?” Mydei’s voice was quiet, soft—like a secret only they shared.

The moment Phainon’s voice filtered through the speaker, all Mydei could do was close his eyes and listen, knowing that despite everything, they had finally found their way back to each other.

Chapter End Notes

> Finally, why is the text hml or rich text of ao3 so faulty when you copy paste???
>
> Tell me you’re honest opinions on this guys and thank you for reading <3333

End Notes

Y’all I SWEAR I’ll write a top Mydei fanfiction one day, that day just hasn’t come yet (Unless I finish my other draft)

Oh god this took so long to write, like so long. Kudos to anyone who stuck around.

At one point I just got angry because it wasn’t done yet so I just starting typing whatever came into mind to get it over with, and bam, I got this now😍

Also sorry in advance for any Soccer players or people living in New York or Texas, I don’t know shit about any of that😭

Thanks for reading <333

Works inspired by this one

A work in an unrevealed collection

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